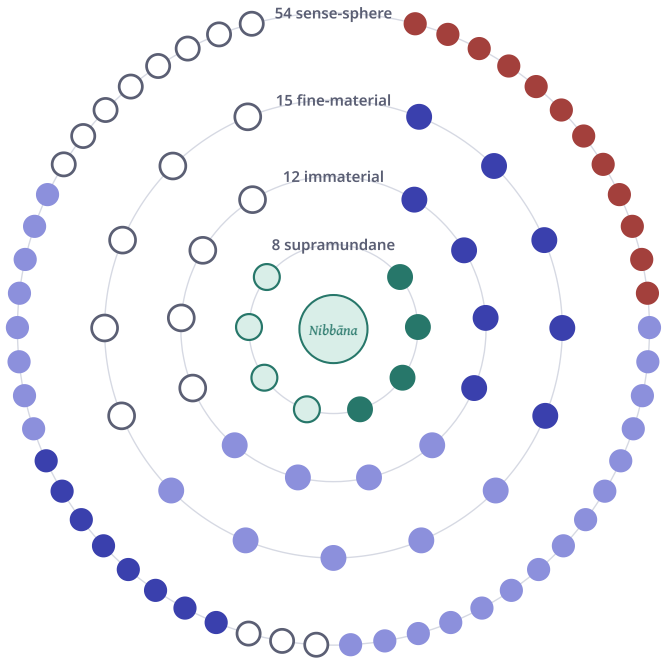
Abhidhamma Atlas

Mind, matter and the conditions that join them: fifteen plates on a seven-level learning path



unwholesome 12 · wholesome 17 · resultant 32 · functional 20 · path 4 · fruit 4

Each dot is one of the 89 kinds of consciousness. The rings run from the sense-sphere on the outside to the supramundane at the centre, where the only object is Nibbāna.

→	**How to learn with this atlas**	2
→	How the main ideas connect	3
→	The Buddha's life as a map	4
I	**Level I · Foundations**	5
1	The library	6
2	From a person to dhammas	7
✦	In the stories	8
II	**Level II · Elements**	9
3	A map of the 89	10
4	The 52 factors as an ensemble	11
5	How matter is made	12
6	The commentators' picture-book	13
✦	In the stories	14
III	**Level III · Process**	15
7	The mango and the moment	16
✦	In the stories	17
IV	**Level IV · Relations**	18
8	The web of 24 conditions	19
9	The wheel across three lives	20
✦	In the stories	21
V	**Level V · Lives and worlds**	22
10	Kamma, death and rebirth	23
11	Thirty-one planes	24
✦	In the stories	25
VI	**Level VI · Practice**	26
12	Forty meditation subjects	27
13	The tree of purification	28
✦	In the stories	29
VII	**Level VII · Synthesis**	30
14	One moment, every lens	31
15	Other maps of the same ground	32
✦	In the stories	33
↯	Threads and glossary	34

Colour key used throughout: indigo, mind · turmeric, matter · teal, Nibbāna · red, unwholesome

A learning path in seven levels

The plates are arranged as a path. Each level answers one question and assumes only the levels before it. Within every level you can work at three depths, taken from the Abhidhamma's own account of how wisdom grows: from learning, from reflection and from development. Read down a column to deepen one level; read across a row to climb.

	I Foundations	II Elements	III Process	IV Relations	V Lives and worlds	VI Practice	VII Synthesis
Question	*What is being taken apart?*	*What is experience made of?*	*How does it unfold?*	*How does it hold together?*	*What carries on, and where?*	*What do I do with it?*	*How does it all fit?*
Plates	1 2	3 4 5 6	7	8 9	10 11	12 13	14 15
Learn *suta*	Name the 7 books and 4 realities	Classify cittas, factors and matter	List the 17 moments and their jobs	Name the 6 families and 12 links	Sort kamma 4 ways; the 31 planes	40 subjects; 7 purifications; 10 fetters	The counts of three schools
Reflect *cintā*	Why a convention is not a falsehood	Why some factors never meet	Why kamma is made only in javana	Why most conditions are simultaneous	How rebirth hangs on the last process	Why calm is the root of insight	What a different view of time would change
Observe *bhāvanā*	See one moment as five aggregates	Notice the feeling-tone of moments	Catch the gap between hearing and naming	Trace a craving back to a contact	Watch which thoughts are habitual	Practise one subject for a week	Read one moment through every lens

Three depths of understanding

- **Learn** · *sutamayā paññā*, wisdom from hearing and study. Know the lists, the terms and the diagrams.
- **Reflect** · *cintāmayā paññā*, wisdom from thinking it through. See why the lists are built as they are, and how the plates connect.
- **Observe** · *bhāvanāmayā paññā*, wisdom from development. Recognise the same things in your own experience.

Dīgha Nikāya 33; Vibhaṅga. The tradition's matching triad is study, practice and realisation (*pariyatti, paṭipatti, paṭivedha*).

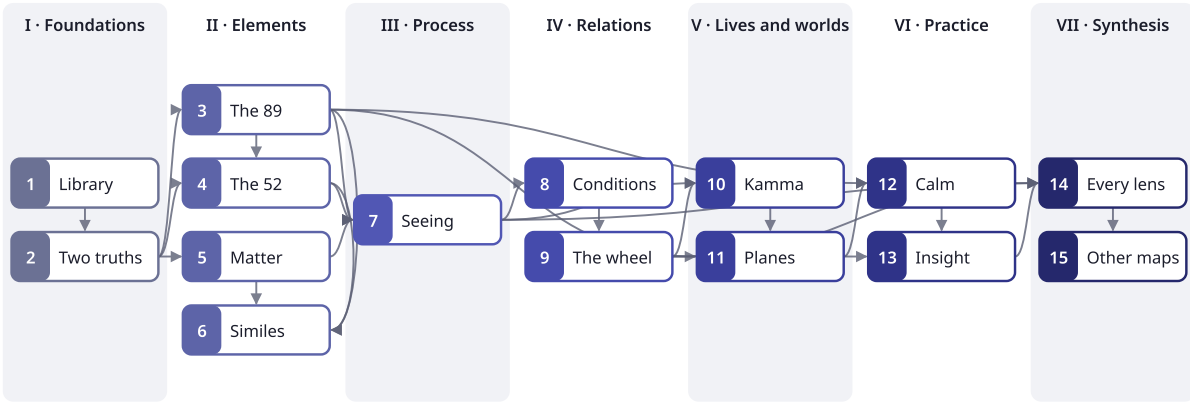
Three routes through the atlas

Full course
every level page and plate, in order
Level I → 1 → 2 → Level II → … → Threads

Quick tour
the core in six plates
2 Two truths → 3 The 89 → 7 Seeing → 9 The wheel → 13 Insight → 14 Every lens

Practitioner's route
from the elements to the path
2 Two truths → 4 The 52 → 7 Seeing → 9 The wheel → 12 Calm → 13 Insight → 14 Every lens

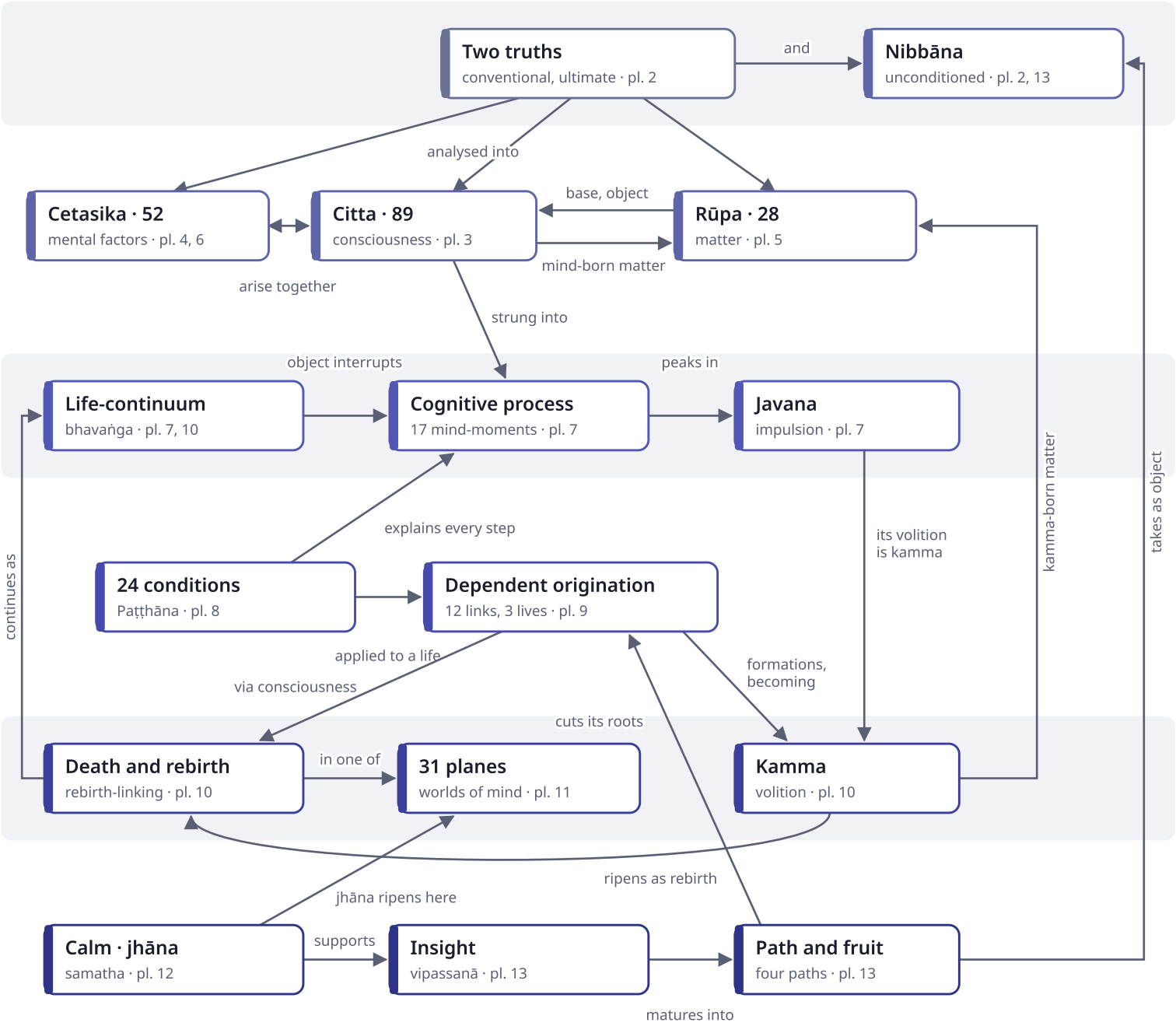
WHICH PLATES BUILD ON WHICH



Each arrow means “read this first”. Every level page lists what you should arrive with and what you should leave able to do.

How the main ideas connect

Sixteen main ideas and the relations that join them. Rows follow Levels I to VI, and each box names the plates that teach it. Read every arrow as a sentence: *Javana, its volition is kamma, Kamma.* Come back to this page after each level and you will find more of it makes sense.



THREE LOOPS WORTH TRACING ON THE MAP

The loop of a life

Kamma → Rebirth → Life-continuum → Process → Javana → Kamma

Each javana adds kamma; kamma shapes the next life; that life's moments make more javanas. → 7 → 10

Mind and matter hold each other up

Rūpa → Citta → Rūpa

Matter gives mind its bases and objects; mind gives matter its movements; kamma builds the sense organs. → 5 → 8

The way out

Calm → Insight → Path → Nibbāna

The path cuts ignorance and craving, the two roots of the wheel, so the first loop stops turning. → 9 → 13

The Buddha's life as a map of the atlas

Every idea in these plates appears somewhere in a life story: the Bodhisatta's past lives in the Jātakas, and the last life of Siddhattha Gotama. Read down either line, follow the coloured plate numbers into the atlas, and use the story links to reach the retellings that close each level.

PAST LIVES · JĀTAKA AND BUDDHAVAṂSA

- Bv II — **Sumedha at Dīpaṅkara's feet** story
  the vow; four incalculable aeons of perfections begin
  10 11
- Ja 313 — **Khantivādi Jātaka** story
  patience under torture, without anger
  4 10
- Ja 407 — **Mahākapi Jātaka** story
  a monkey king's body as a bridge
  4
- Ja 9 — **Makhādeva Jātaka** story
  a first grey hair, and renunciation
  7 13
- Ja 538 — **Mūgapakkha Jātaka**
  Prince Temiya remembers a hell, and refuses the throne
  10 11
- Ja 541 — **Nimi Jātaka** story
  a chariot ride past the hells and heavens
  11
- Ja 547 — **Vessantara Jātaka** story
  the last human life before the final one: giving perfected
  10
- Jātaka introduction — **A deva in Tusita**
  waiting for the final birth
  11

↘ From Tusita to the final birth

THE LAST LIFE · SIDDHATTHA GOTAMA

- age 0 — **Birth at Lumbinī**
  rebirth-linking in the human world
  10
- childhood · MN 36 — **The rose-apple tree** story
  a child enters the first jhāna
  3 12
- age 29 — **Going forth**
  old age, sickness, death and a recluse
  13
- MN 26 — **Two teachers** story
  nothingness; neither perception nor non-perception
  11 12
- age 35 · MN 36, Ud 1 — **Awakening** story
  three watches of the night; dependent origination
  9 10 13
- commentary — **The Jewel House** story
  the fourth week: contemplating the Abhidhamma
  1 8
- SN 56.11 — **First sermon** story
  Koṇḍaññā: all that arises ceases
  13
- SN 22.59 — **Not-self**
  five monks become arahants
  2 13
- Vin Mv I.23 — **Assaji's verse** story
  Sāriputta hears of causes and their cessation
  8 9
- commentary — **A rains in Tāvatiṃsa** story
  the Abhidhamma taught to devas and his mother
  1 11
- MN 86 — **Aṅgulimāla** story
  a murderer becomes an arahant, and meets old kamma
  10
- age 80 · DN 16 — **Final Nibbāna** story
  through the jhānas, at Kusinārā
  3 13

Why stories belong in an Abhidhamma atlas

The Abhidhamma speaks in dhammas, not people. The commentaries that teach it, though, are full of people: the Atthasālinī and the Visuddhimagga constantly turn to the Buddha's life, his disciples and the Jātakas to show a dhamma at work. A story gives one concrete case; the plates give the general structure. Going back and forth between the two is the Reflect depth of this atlas.

LEVEL I OF VII · PLATES 1–2

I Foundations

What is the Abhidhamma, and what does it take apart?

I · Foundations | II · Elements | III · Process | IV · Relations | V · Lives and worlds | VI · Practice | VII · Synthesis

YOU ARRIVE WITH

No background is needed. A little familiarity with the five aggregates of the suttas helps.

YOU LEAVE ABLE TO

- Name the seven books and the main later works.
- Tell conventional truth from ultimate truth.
- Map the five aggregates onto the four ultimate realities.
- Read the four-part definition the commentaries give every dhamma.

1 The library

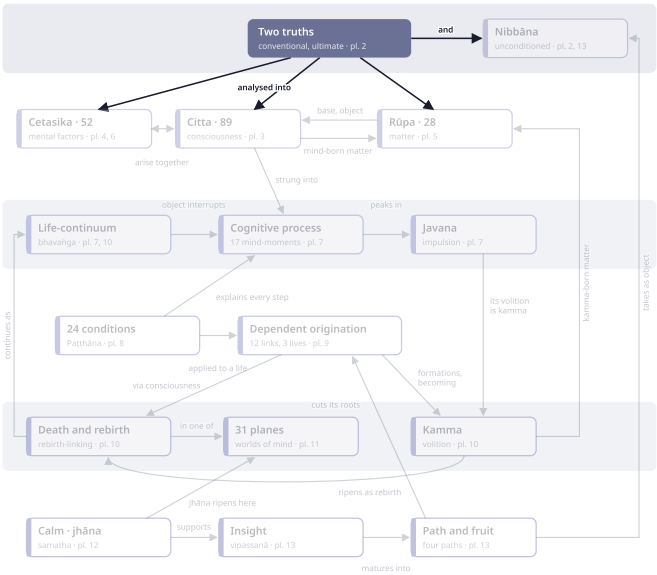
Seven books, and the commentaries and manuals that grew around them.

2 From a person to dhammas

How "a person" resolves into four kinds of ultimate reality.

✦ In the stories

Episodes from the Buddha's life, the Jātakas and the disciples, read with these plates.



Filled: this level. Outlined: earlier levels. Faded: what comes later. Bold arrows touch this level.

CHECK YOURSELF AT THREE DEPTHS

Learn *suta*

recall the lists and terms

1. Name the four ultimate realities and how many kinds each has.
2. Which book analyses, and which one relates everything by condition?

Reflect *cintā*

connect and explain

1. The Abhidhamma calls "chariot" a convention, not a falsehood. What would be lost if conventions were simply false?
2. Why might a four-part definition teach more than a one-line gloss?

Observe *bhāvanā*

find it in experience

1. Take one ordinary moment, such as drinking tea, and list which of the five aggregates were present in it.

Common confusions

≠ "Ultimate" does not mean hidden or permanent. Dhammas are momentary events, and they are exactly what is directly experienced.

≠ The Abhidhamma does not throw persons away. One of its seven books, the Puggalapaññatti, is about types of people.

I Foundations Start of the path Leads to 2

Seven books, and the shelves that grew around them

The Abhidhamma Piṭaka is the third basket of the Pāli Canon. Its first book takes experience apart. Its last book puts the parts back together as a web of conditions. Nearly everything written since is commentary, summary or teaching aid for these seven.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Dhammasaṅgaṇī	*Vibhaṅga*	*Dhātukathā*	*Puggalapaññatti*	*Kathāvatthu*	*Yamaka*	*Paṭṭhāna*
Enumeration of phenomena Opens with the mātikā, 22 triads and 100 dyads, then analyses each kind of citta into its factors.	**Book of analysis** Eighteen chapters, each treated by the sutta method, the Abhidhamma method and by questions.	**Discussion of elements** Shows how each dhamma is included in, or excluded from, the aggregates, bases and elements.	**Designation of persons** Types of people. The one book about conventional rather than ultimate reality.	**Points of controversy** Refutes the views of other early schools in debate form.	**Book of pairs** Pins down the scope of each term with paired, converse questions.	**Conditional relations** Applies 24 conditions to every dhamma. The largest book, called the Great Treatise.

← **analysis**: breaking wholes into dhammas **synthesis**: relating dhammas by condition →

THERAVĀDA: EACH LAYER COMMENTS ON THE ONE ABOVE

Canon c. 3rd–1st c. BCE
- Abhidhamma Piṭaka, 7 books
- Kathāvatthu attributed to Moggaliputta Tissa, Third Council
- written down in Sri Lanka, 1st c. BCE

Commentaries 5th c. CE
- *Atthasālinī* on the Dhammasaṅgaṇī
- *Sammohavinodanī* on the Vibhaṅga
- *Pañcappakaraṇa-aṭṭhakathā* on the other five
- *Visuddhimagga* (all by Buddhaghosa)
- *Abhidhammāvatāra*, Buddhadatta

Subcommentaries after the 5th c.
- *Mūlaṭīkā*, Ānanda
- *Anuṭīkā*, Dhammapāla

Manuals c. 10th–12th c.
- *Abhidhammattha Saṅgaha*, Anuruddha
- *Vibhāvinī-ṭīkā*, Sumaṅgala, late 12th c.

Burmese revival 1890s
- *Paramatthadīpanī*, Ledi Sayadaw: disputes the Vibhāvinī on 245 points

In English 1949–2010
- Nyanaponika, *Abhidhamma Studies* 1949
- Nārada, *A Manual of Abhidhamma* 1956
- van Gorkom, *Abhidhamma in Daily Life* 1975
- Bodhi (ed.), *A Comprehensive Manual* 1993
- Mehm Tin Mon, *The Essence of Buddhist Abhidhamma* 1995
- Karunadasa, *The Theravāda Abhidhamma* 2010

A PARALLEL SHELF: NORTHERN ABHIDHARMA

- Sarvāstivāda: seven treatises, led by the *Jñānaprasthāna*
- *Mahāvibhāṣā*, c. 2nd c. CE
- *Abhidharmakośa*, Vasubandhu, c. 4th–5th c.
- Yogācāra: Asaṅga's *Abhidharmasamuccaya*; the hundred dharmas

These lists grew from the same early matrices (*mātikā*) but reached different counts. Plate 15 sets them side by side. → 15

Dates before the modern period are approximate and some are disputed. Anuruddha's date, for example, is placed anywhere from the 8th to the 12th century; most modern scholars favour the 10th–12th.

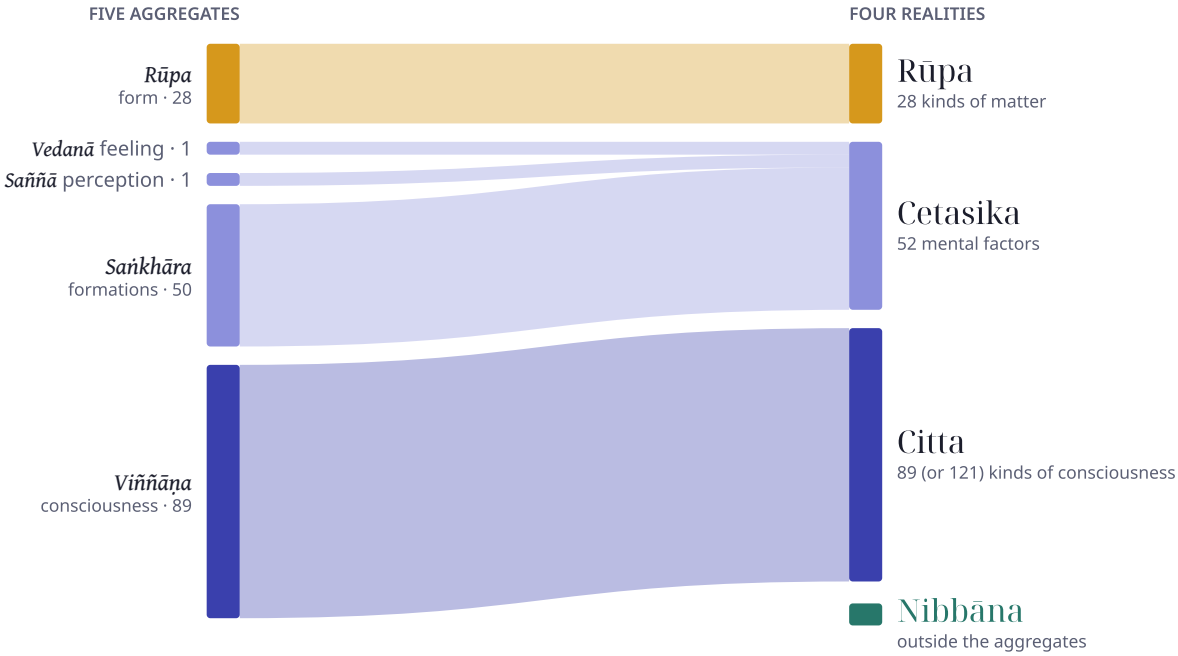
Sources: Bodhi, *CMA* introduction; Encyclopaedia entries on the Abhidhamma literature

I Foundations Builds on 1 Leads to 3 · 4 · 5

citta · feeling · contact · matter · Nibbāna

From a person to dhammas

Ordinary speech talks about people, chariots and mangoes. That is conventional truth (*sammuti-sacca*), and it is not false. The Abhidhamma adds a second level, ultimate truth (*paramattha-sacca*): the irreducible events, or *dhammas*, that the conventions are built from. The five aggregates of the suttas map directly onto the four ultimate realities.



Band widths are proportional to the number of kinds of dhamma. Feeling and perception are one mental factor each, so their bands are drawn at a minimum width. Formations hold the other 50 factors. Nibbāna belongs to no aggregate. Each reality has its own plate: citta → 3, cetasika → 4, rūpa → 5.

The chariot

"Chariot" is the name used when axle, wheels, frame and pole are assembled; no chariot is found apart from them. In the same way, "a being" is the convention used when the aggregates are present. Nun Vajirā says this in the Saṃyutta Nikāya, and Nāgasena makes the same point to King Milinda.

Buddhaghosa adds a wordplay: *nāma*, mind, is so called because it bends (*namati*) toward its object; *rūpa*, matter, because it is "afflicted" (*ruppati*) by cold, heat and the like.

SN 5.10; Milindapañha II.1; Visuddhimagga XVIII

How the commentaries define a dhamma

Every dhamma gets the same four-part "identity card". Learn the template once and every definition in the Atthasālinī and Visuddhimagga becomes easy to read.

- **Characteristic** (*lakkhaṇa*): its own nature
- **Function** (*rasa*): what it does
- **Manifestation** (*paccupaṭṭhāna*): how it shows up in experience
- **Proximate cause** (*padaṭṭhāna*): what it most directly depends on

phassa	contact · universal
CHARACTERISTIC	touching the object
FUNCTION	impingement
MANIFESTATION	the coming together of base, object and consciousness
PROXIMATE CAUSE	an object that has come into focus

sati	mindfulness · beautiful
CHARACTERISTIC	not wobbling, not floating away from the object
FUNCTION	absence of confusion, non-forgetfulness
MANIFESTATION	guarding; facing the object
PROXIMATE CAUSE	strong perception, or the four foundations of mindfulness

I Foundations Retells and reads plates 1–2 ● the Buddha's life ● Jātaka ● disciples

Foundations in the stories

The tradition has always taught through lives. Each story is retold briefly from its source. The second part reads it with the plates of this level; those readings are study aids, not claims made by the texts themselves.

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE Atthasālinī, introduction

Where the Abhidhamma was first taught

The commentary tells that the Buddha spent a rainy season in the Tāvatiṃsa heaven, teaching the Abhidhamma to the devas, among them his mother, reborn as a deva. Each day he came down to Lake Anotatta, where he gave Sāriputta the outline, and Sāriputta taught it to five hundred monks. At the end of the rains he descended at Saṅkassa. The Tipiṭaka itself does not tell this story.

READ WITH THE ATLAS This is the tradition's account of where the seven books of Plate 1 came from, and why Sāriputta is honoured as the first teacher of the Abhidhamma. → 1 → 11

REFLECT *Why might a tradition place the first teaching of the Abhidhamma among devas rather than humans?*

JĀTAKA Jātaka, closing identification

The last line of every Jātaka

Each Jātaka ends by naming who was who: “At that time, so-and-so was the king, and I myself was the ascetic.” One continuity is followed across many lives as if it were one person.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Conventional truth at work (Plate 2). Ultimately there is only a stream of cittas and matter, each moment conditioning the next. “The Bodhisatta” names the stream: neither the same person, nor a different one. → 2 → 10

REFLECT *What does the word “I” refer to in “I was the ascetic”?*

DISCIPLES SN 22.87

Vakkali and the body

The monk Vakkali longed to keep looking at the Buddha. The Buddha said: “Enough, Vakkali. What is there to see in this foul body? Whoever sees the Dhamma sees me.”

READ WITH THE ATLAS Even “the Buddha” is a convention for aggregates. What is really to be seen are dhammas and their characteristics, the shift Plate 2 asks of you. → 2

REFLECT *What would it mean to see a teacher in dhammas rather than as a person?*

DISCIPLES SN 5.10

Nun Vajirā's chariot

Māra asked the nun Vajirā who had created “this being”. She answered: “Why do you assume a being? This is a heap of formations. As the word ‘chariot’ is used when the parts are assembled, so ‘a being’ is the convention when the aggregates are present.”

READ WITH THE ATLAS Her reply is the hinge of Plate 2: the five aggregates on the left of its diagram, the convention “a being” on top of them. → 2

REFLECT *Is Vajirā saying that beings do not exist, or saying what the word refers to?*

II

LEVEL II OF VII · PLATES 3–6

Elements

What is experience made of?

I · Foundations | **II · Elements** | III · Process | IV · Relations | V · Lives and worlds | VI · Practice | VII · Synthesis

YOU ARRIVE WITH

Level I: the four realities and the two truths.

YOU LEAVE ABLE TO

- Place any citta by plane, ethical kind and feeling.
- Tell the 7 universals from the 6 occasionals, and say why unwholesome and beautiful factors never meet.
- Name the four origins of matter and the eight inseparables.
- Explain contact, feeling, perception or volition with a commentarial simile.

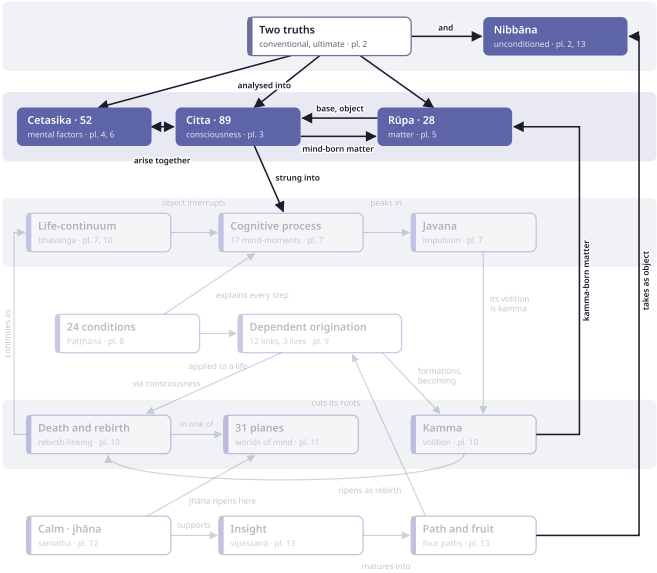
3 A map of the 89
Every kind of consciousness, coloured by the feeling it carries.

4 The 52 factors as an ensemble
Seven factors in every moment, and two families that never mix.

5 How matter is made
28 kinds of matter, four origins, 21 kalāpas.

6 The commentators' picture-book
The similes that make the elements memorable.

✦ In the stories
Episodes from the Buddha's life, the Jātakas and the disciples, read with these plates.



Filled: this level. Outlined: earlier levels. Faded: what comes later. Bold arrows touch this level.

CHECK YOURSELF AT THREE DEPTHS

Learn *suta*

recall the lists and terms

1. Name the seven universal factors.
2. Which four things produce matter, and which kinds does only kamma produce?

Reflect *cintā*

connect and explain

1. Displeasure appears only in the two hate-rooted cittas. What does that suggest about mental pain and aversion?
2. Feeling is a universal factor. Can any moment of mind be entirely without feeling-tone?

Observe *bhāvanā*

find it in experience

1. Note the feeling-tone of the next ten things you see: pleasant, unpleasant or neutral.
2. When irritation arises, look for pleasure in the very same moment. Can you find it, or do they alternate?

Common confusions

≠ Vedanā is not emotion. It is only the pleasant, painful or neutral tone of a moment; an emotion is a complex of many factors.

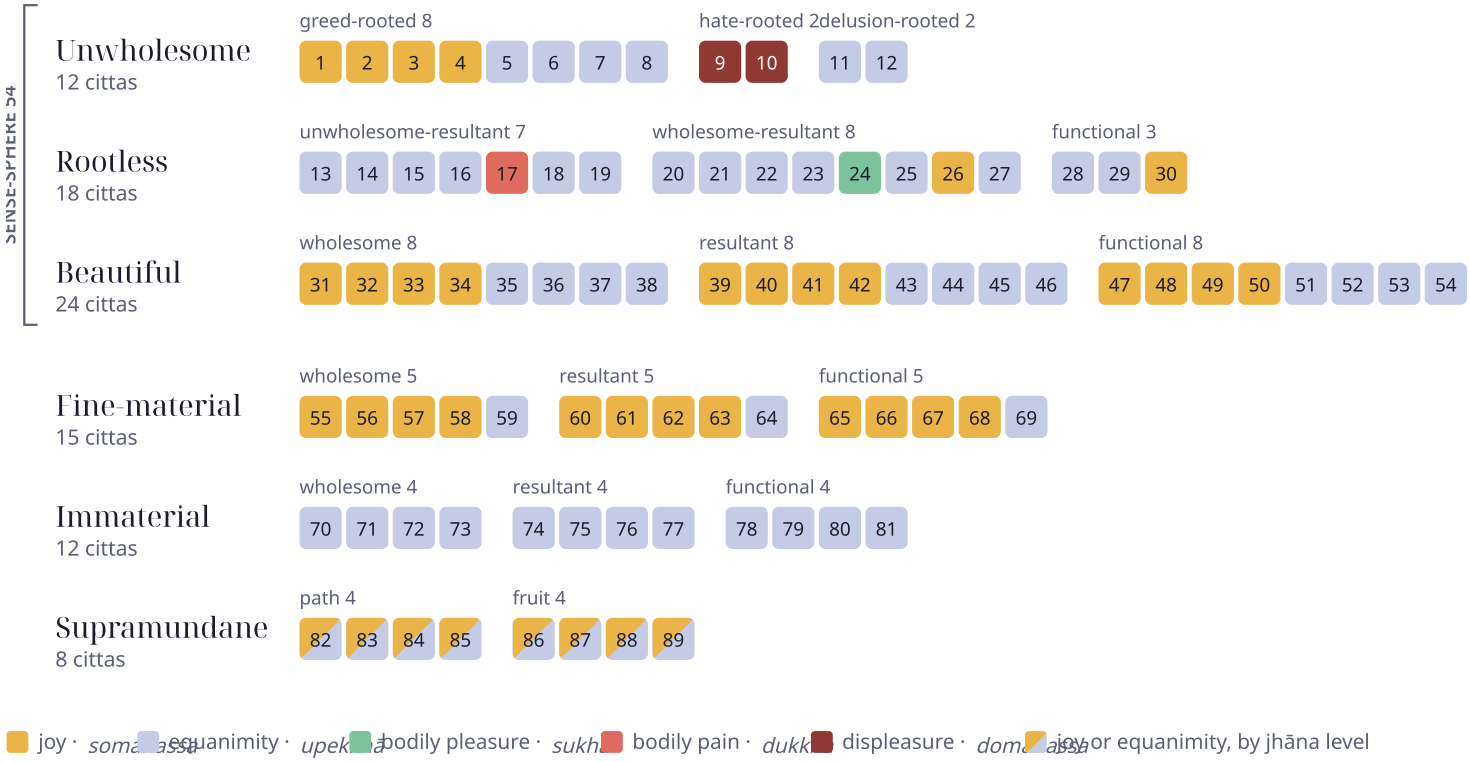
≠ Rūpa is not just visible form. It includes the sense organs, sound, the heart-base and nutritive essence.

≠ Citta and its factors are not separate things that meet. They arise together, cease together and share one object and one base.

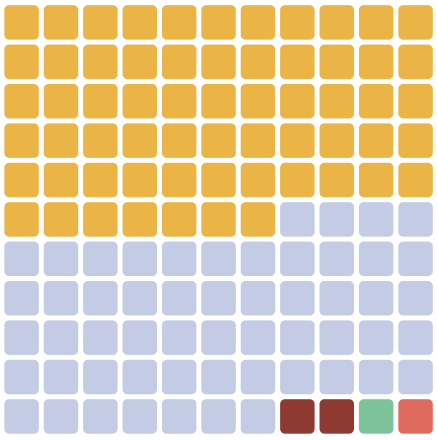
II Elements Builds on 2 Leads to 4 · 6 · 7 · 11 · 12 citta feeling jhāna

A map of the 89, coloured by feeling

The usual chart sorts consciousness by plane and by ethical quality. Colour it by the feeling (*vedanā*) that each citta carries and a pattern appears: most of the mind's moments are neutral, joy is common in wholesome states, and pain and displeasure are surprisingly rare.



joy · *somanassa* equanimity · *upekkhā* bodily pleasure · *sukha* bodily pain · *dukkha* displeasure · *domanassa* joy or equanimity, by jhāna level



62 joy
55 equanimity
2 displeasure
1 pleasure
1 pain

121 cittas, one square each

What the colours say

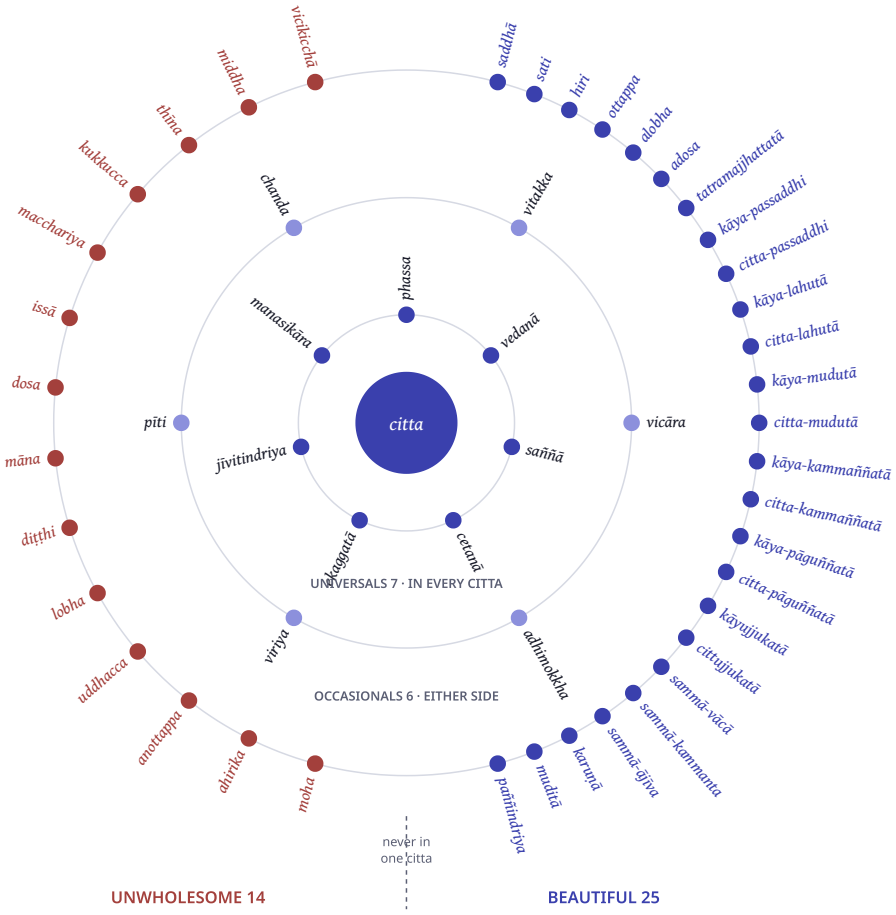
- Counted as 121, joy accompanies 62 cittas and equanimity 55. Only four cittas carry any other feeling.
- Bodily pleasure and bodily pain occur in exactly one citta each: wholesome-resultant and unwholesome-resultant body-consciousness.
- Displeasure occurs only in the two hate-rooted cittas. Wherever there is displeasure, there is aversion.
- Every immaterial citta is equanimous, and so is the fifth jhāna. The higher the concentration, the quieter the feeling.
- The fine-material and immaterial rows are the minds of jhāna. Each has its own worlds → 11 and its own meditation subjects → 12.

II Elements Builds on 2 · 3 Leads to 6 · 7

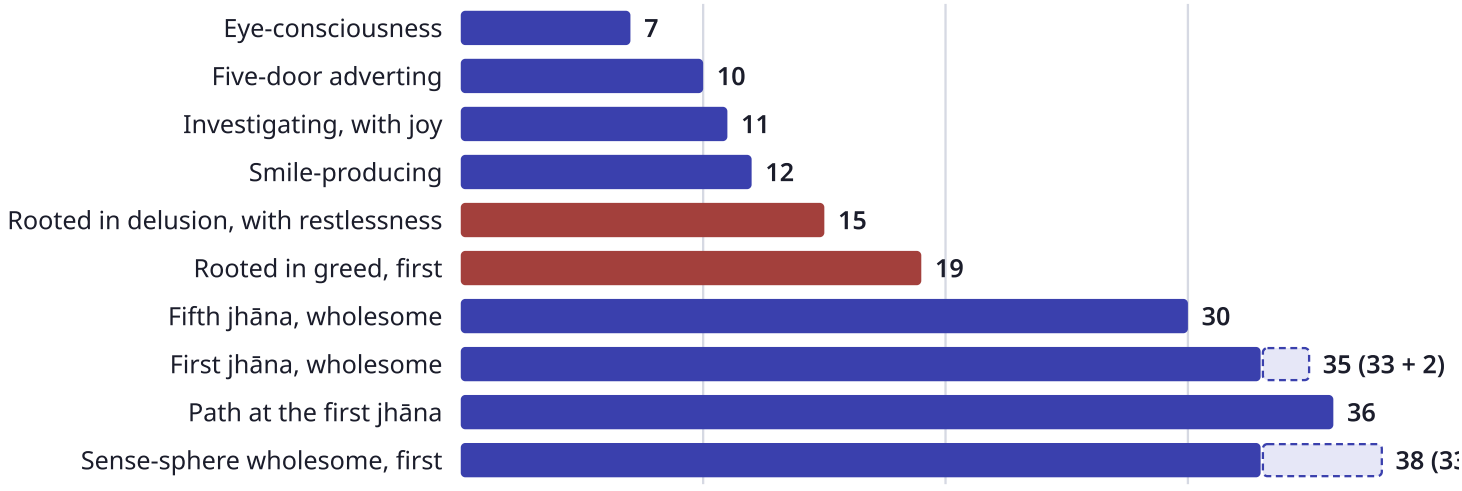
citta · feeling · contact · kamma · roots · jhāna · wisdom

The 52 mental factors as an ensemble

Picture the factors as players gathered around citta. Seven play in every moment of mind. Six more join when the music calls for them. The two outer sections, unwholesome and beautiful, never play in the same moment.



HOW MANY FACTORS JOIN EACH KIND OF CITTA



always present · may join, one at a time · includes unwholesome factors

Three factors carry the story forward. Volition (*cetanā*) is kamma → 10. Contact starts the chain of feeling and craving → 9. Wisdom (*paññindriya*) grows into the insight knowledges → 13.

Source: Bodhi, *CMA* II (combinations of mental factors)

II Elements Builds on 2 Leads to 6 · 7 kamma matter time

How matter is made

Four things produce matter: kamma, mind, temperature and nutriment. The matrix shows which kinds each one makes. Matter never arises alone; it comes in packets called *kalāpas*, and every packet carries the same eight inseparables.

		kamma	mind	temp.	food	none
CONCRETE 18	*pathavī*	earth	■	■	■	■	·
	āpo	water	■	■	■	■	·
	tejo	fire	■	■	■	■	·
	vāyo	air	■	■	■	■	·
	cakkhu	eye-sensitivity	■	·	·	·	·
	sota	ear-sensitivity	■	·	·	·	·
	ghāna	nose-sensitivity	■	·	·	·	·
	jivhā	tongue-sensitivity	■	·	·	·	·
	kāya	body-sensitivity	■	·	·	·	·
	vaṇṇa	visible form	■	■	■	■	·
	sadda	sound	·	■	■	·	·
	gandha	smell	■	■	■	■	·
	rasa	taste	■	■	■	■	·
	itthibhāva	femininity	■	·	·	·	·
	purisabhāva	masculinity	■	·	·	·	·
	hadaya	heart-base	■	·	·	·	·
	jīvita	life faculty	■	·	·	·	·
	ojā	nutritive essence	■	■	■	■	·
NON-CONCRETE 10	*ākāsa*	space	■	■	■	■	·
	kāya-viññatti	bodily intimation	·	■	·	·	·
	vacī-viññatti	vocal intimation	·	■	·	·	·
	lahutā	lightness	·	■	■	■	·
	mudutā	malleability	·	■	■	■	·
	kammaññatā	wieldiness	·	■	■	■	·
	upacaya	production	·	·	·	·	■
	santati	continuity	·	·	·	·	■
	jaratā	decay	·	·	·	·	■
	aniccatā	impermanence	·	·	·	·	■
	kinds produced		18	15	13	12	4

ONE UNIT OF MATTER OUTLIVES SEVENTEEN CITTAS

17 CITTAS × 3 SUB-MOMENTS

presence · 49 sub-moments

↑ arising: 1 dissolution: 1 ↑

Matter is slow to change, so many minds pass over one body.

THE 21 KALĀPAS

Kamma-born · 9

eye-decad	+ life, eye
ear-decad	+ life, ear
nose-decad	+ life, nose
tongue-decad	+ life, tongue
body-decad	+ life, body
female-decad	+ life, fem.
male-decad	+ life, masc.
heart-base decad	+ life, heart
vital nonad	+ life

Mind-born · 6

pure octad	
bodily intimation nonad	+ b.int
vocal intimation decad	+ v.int, sound
undecad of mutability	
bodily int. + mutability	
vocal int. + sound + mut.	

Temperature-born · 4

pure octad	
sound nonad	+ sound
undecad of mutability	
sound + mutability	

Nutriment-born · 2

pure octad	
undecad of mutability	

□ the eight inseparables ■ added kinds

Space separates the kalāpas, and the four characteristics only mark their arising and decay, so neither is counted inside a group. Kamma-born matter is where this plate meets Plate 10 (→ 10); mind-born matter is how javanas move the body (→ 7).

II Elements Builds on 3 · 4 · 5 Threads and glossary

citta feeling contact kamma matter wisdom

The commentators' picture-book

The canonical Abhidhamma is lists and tables. The commentaries brought it to life with similes. Each one is chosen to show a single property, not to tell a whole story, so it pays to ask what the picture is pointing at.

Three people look at a heap of coins



A child
sees shapes and colours
saññā · perception >

A villager
knows: money, can be spent
viññāṇa · consciousness >

A money-changer
knows: genuine or false, c
paññā · understanding

A child sees shapes and colours but does not know the coins are money. A villager knows they are money and can be spent. A money-changer knows which are genuine, which are false, where they were struck and what they weigh. So perception (*saññā*) notes the surface, consciousness (*viññāṇa*) knows the object as such, and understanding (*paññā*) penetrates its characteristics.

Visuddhimagga XIV, on "in what sense is it understanding?"

Contact *phassa*

Two rams butting heads: one is the eye, one is the visible object, and their meeting is contact. Or two hands clapping.

Milindapañha → 4 → 9

Feeling *vedanā*

A cook tastes a dish while preparing it; the king enjoys the whole meal. Other factors touch the object's taste in passing. Feeling, as master, enjoys it fully.

Atthasālinī → 3 → 9

Perception *saññā*

A carpenter marks his timber so he can recognise it later. Perception makes a sign, so that next time it can say, "this is the same".

Visuddhimagga XIV → 4

Volition *cetanā*

A head pupil recites his own lesson and makes the others recite theirs. Volition does its own work and sets the other factors to theirs.

Atthasālinī → 4 → 10

Applied and sustained thought *vitakka, vicāra*

Striking a bell, and its ringing on. A bird spreading its wings to take off, and gliding. A bee diving onto a lotus, and moving over it once landed.

Visuddhimagga IV; Milindapañha has a gong → 12

Mind and matter *nāma-rūpa*

A blind man carrying a lame man who can see: neither can travel alone. Also a puppet that moves only through wood and strings, and two sheaves of reeds propped against each other.

Visuddhimagga XVIII → 5 → 13

II Elements Retells and reads plates 3–6 ● the Buddha's life ● Jātaka ● disciples

Elements in the stories

The tradition has always taught through lives. Each story is retold briefly from its source. The second part reads it with the plates of this level; those readings are study aids, not claims made by the texts themselves.

DISCIPLES Dhammapada commentary, v. 114

Kisāgotamī and the mustard seed

Mad with grief, Kisāgotamī carried her dead child from house to house asking for medicine. The Buddha asked her for a mustard seed from a house where no one had died. She found none, laid the child down, and understood that death comes to all.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Her grief is displeasure (domanassa), which on Plate 3 occurs only in the two hate-rooted cittas: grief is aversion toward loss. The search turned a private wound into a universal fact. → 3 → 4

REFLECT *Why would the Abhidhamma class grief with aversion rather than with love?*

DISCIPLES SN 19.1

Why Moggallāna smiled

Coming down Vulture Peak, Mahā Moggallāna smiled. Asked why, he said he had seen a skeleton moving through the air, pursued by crows and vultures. The Buddha confirmed that he too had seen such beings, and named the deeds that led there.

READ WITH THE ATLAS An arahant's smile comes from citta 30 on Plate 3, the smile-producing consciousness, found only in arahants and making no kamma. What he saw belongs to the woeful planes of Plate 11. → 3 → 11

REFLECT *In terms of citta, how does an ordinary person's smile differ from an arahant's?*

JĀTAKA Ja 313

Khantivādi, the teacher of patience

A drunken king, Kalābu, asked an ascetic what he taught. “Patience,” he said. To test him, the king had his hands, feet, nose and ears cut off. The ascetic felt no anger and wished the king long life. Leaving, the king was swallowed by the earth.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Plate 4 at its sharpest: non-hatred (adosa) and hatred (dosa) never share a citta. The king's fate returns on Plate 10 as kamma that ripens in this very life. → 4 → 10

REFLECT *Is patience only the absence of anger, or the presence of something else?*

JĀTAKA Ja 407

The monkey king's bridge

To save his troop from archers, a monkey king stretched himself across a river as a living bridge. The troop crossed over his back, but a jealous monkey leapt on him and broke it. The king of Benares, moved, tended him as he died.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Compassion (karuṇā) is one of the variable beautiful factors on Plate 4. It joins a wholesome citta only now and then, when the suffering of others is the object. → 4 → 12

REFLECT *Why does compassion need suffering as its object, while loving-kindness does not?*

DISCIPLES MN 44

Dhammadinnā on feeling

Questioned by the layman Visākha, the nun Dhammadinnā explained that lust lies latent in pleasant feeling, aversion in painful feeling and ignorance in neutral feeling. The Buddha said he would have answered in the same way.

READ WITH THE ATLAS This joins Plate 3's colours to Plate 9's wheel: feeling (link 7) is where craving (link 8) takes hold. → 3 → 9

REFLECT *Which tendency does neutral feeling feed, and why is it the hardest to notice?*

DISCIPLES MN 140

Pukkusāti and the elements

One night in a potter's shed, the Buddha taught a stranger, Pukkusāti, to see his body as earth, water, fire, air, space and consciousness, none of it “mine”. Pukkusāti recognised his teacher, but while seeking robes for ordination he was killed by a cow. The Buddha declared him a non-returner.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The four great elements are the core of the 28 kinds of matter on Plate 5. Analysing the body into elements is also one of the forty meditation subjects on Plate 12. → 5 → 12

REFLECT *If hardness, cohesion, heat and motion are all there is in “my hand”, what does “my” point to?*

III

LEVEL III OF VII · PLATE 7

Process

How does experience unfold, moment by moment?

I · Foundations | II · Elements | **III · Process** | IV · Relations | V · Lives and worlds | VI · Practice | VII · Synthesis

YOU ARRIVE WITH

Level II: the kinds of citta, especially the rootless ones, and the lifespan of matter.

YOU LEAVE ABLE TO

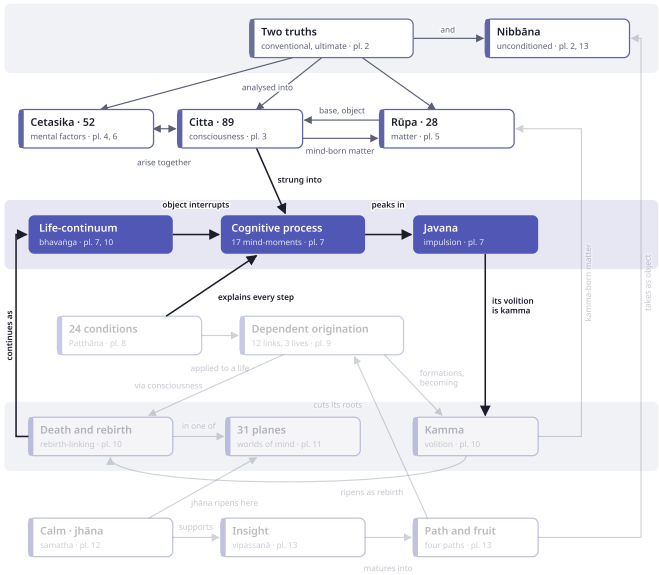
- List the 17 moments of a five-door process and the job of each.
- Explain why new kamma is made only in the javanas.
- Say how weaker objects cut the process short, and how the mind-door process differs.

7 The mango and the moment

A 17-moment process of seeing, told through the mango simile.

✦ In the stories

Episodes from the Buddha's life, the Jātakas and the disciples, read with these plates.



Filled: this level. Outlined: earlier levels. Faded: what comes later. Bold arrows touch this level.

CHECK YOURSELF AT THREE DEPTHS

Learn *suta*

recall the lists and terms

1. At which moment does seeing occur? Which moments make kamma?
2. What happens when the object is only "slight"?

Reflect *cintā*

connect and explain

1. Eye-consciousness is the result of past kamma, but the javanas make new kamma. Where, then, is the room for choice in a moment of seeing?
2. Why can a very weak object produce no javana at all?

Observe *bhāvanā*

find it in experience

1. When a sound catches your attention, notice the brief gap between hearing it and naming it.

Common confusions

≠ Bhavaṅga is not a self or a soul. It is a resultant citta that arises and ceases like any other.

≠ The 17 moments are not a slow sequence you can watch one by one. They describe structure, far below the speed of ordinary awareness.

≠ Javana is not a separate decision-maker. It is a run of, usually, seven similar cittas.

III Process Builds on 3 · 4 · 5 Leads to 8 · 10 · 14 citta kamma matter bhavaṅga time

The mango and the moment

The Atthasālinī explains a seventeen-moment process of seeing with a story about a man asleep under a mango tree. Read the two columns together: the left is the Abhidhamma, the right is the picture.

1	*Atīta-bhavaṅga* past life-continuum	A man sleeps at the foot of a mango tree, his head covered. A breeze stirs the branches and a mango falls beside his head.
2	*Bhavaṅga-calana* vibrating life-continuum	
3	*Bhavaṅgupaccheda* arrest of life-continuum	
4	*Pañcadvārāvajjana* five-door adverting	He uncovers his head and turns toward the fruit.
5	*Cakkhu-viññāṇa* eye-consciousness	He sees it.
6	*Sampaṭicchana* receiving	He picks it up.
7	*Santīraṇa* investigating	He looks it over.
8	*Voṭṭhapana* determining	He decides: a ripe mango.
9	*Javana 1* impulsion	He eats it. Here, and only here, the mind acts: liking or disliking, wisdom or its absence. This is where kamma is made. → 10
10	*Javana 2* impulsion	
11	*Javana 3* impulsion	
12	*Javana 4* impulsion	
13	*Javana 5* impulsion	
14	*Javana 6* impulsion	
15	*Javana 7* impulsion	
16	*Tadārammaṇa 1* registration	He swallows the last of it. †
17	*Tadārammaṇa 2* registration	
	Bhavaṅga life-continuum	He goes back to sleep. †

† The Atthasālinī's version stops when the man eats the mango. Swallowing and going back to sleep were added by later teachers, for example in the *Vibhāvinī-ṭīkā*, to cover registration and the return to the life-continuum.

NOT EVERY OBJECT COMPLETES THE PROCESS

Very great object: complete, with registration



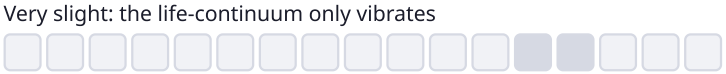
Great: 2–3 past moments, no registration



Slight: no javana; determining repeats



Very slight: the life-continuum only vibrates



Mind-door, clear object



How fast is a moment?

The commentaries say that billions of cittas can arise and cease in the time it takes lightning to flash or an eye to blink. The seventeen moments are not a slow story; they are a description of structure.

Why seventeen?

A unit of matter lasts seventeen mind-moments. A sense object strikes the door at the first moment and is gone after the seventeenth, so a single object can carry exactly one complete process. A weaker impact starts later and runs out sooner.

life-continuum process citta sense consciousness javana registration

III Process Retells and reads plate 7

● the Buddha's life ● Jātaka ● disciples

Process in the stories

The tradition has always taught through lives. Each story is retold briefly from its source. The second part reads it with the plates of this level; those readings are study aids, not claims made by the texts themselves.

DISCIPLES Ud 1.10

Bāhiya: in the seen, only the seen

Bāhiya stopped the Buddha on his alms round, begging to be taught. The Buddha said: "In the seen there will be only the seen, in the heard only the heard, in the sensed only the sensed, in the cognized only the cognized." Bāhiya became an arahant there and then, and was killed by a cow soon after.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Plate 7 shows where the instruction bites. Seeing itself, at moment 5, is a result and makes no kamma. Liking, disliking and "I" enter only in the javanas. → 7 → 2

REFLECT *At which moment of Plate 7 does "the seen" become "a mango I want"?*

DISCIPLES Ud 3.2; AN 8.9

Nanda, guardian of the doors

The Buddha's half-brother Nanda was ordained on his wedding day and pined for his bride. In time he became an arahant, and the Buddha named him foremost among those who guard the sense doors: whichever way Nanda looked, he looked with full awareness, so that longing and grief could not flow in.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The doors of sense restraint are the doors of Plate 7. Guarding them means the seeing is not followed by unwholesome javanas. → 7 → 4

REFLECT *Can a door be guarded without being closed?*

JĀTAKA Ja 9

Makhādeva's first grey hair

King Makhādeva told his barber to report the first grey hair. When it came, the king held it in his hand, saw death approaching, handed the kingdom to his son and went forth.

READ WITH THE ATLAS A small object can carry a large process. The same sight of a grey hair could run javanas of vanity or of urgency; which one runs depends on attention at the turning point of determining (Plate 7). → 7 → 13

REFLECT *What decides whether a grey hair produces worry or wisdom?*

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE MN 61

Rāhula and the mirror

The Buddha asked his young son Rāhula what a mirror is for. "For reflection, sir." "In the same way," said the Buddha, "reflect before, during and after every action of body, speech and mind: does it lead to harm for myself, for others, or both?"

READ WITH THE ATLAS Reflection is a discipline for the javanas, where volition becomes kamma (Plates 7 and 10). → 7 → 10

REFLECT *Why reflect after an action, when its kamma is already made?*

IV

LEVEL IV OF VII · PLATES 8–9

Relations

How does everything hold together?

I · Foundations | II · Elements | III · Process | **IV · Relations** | V · Lives and worlds | VI · Practice | VII · Synthesis

YOU ARRIVE WITH

Level III: the cognitive process. Level II: mind and matter.

YOU LEAVE ABLE TO

- Name the six families of conditions and give an example of each.
- Trace one moment of experience through several conditions.
- Place the 12 links across three lives, and name the connections, rounds and roots.

8 The web of 24 conditions

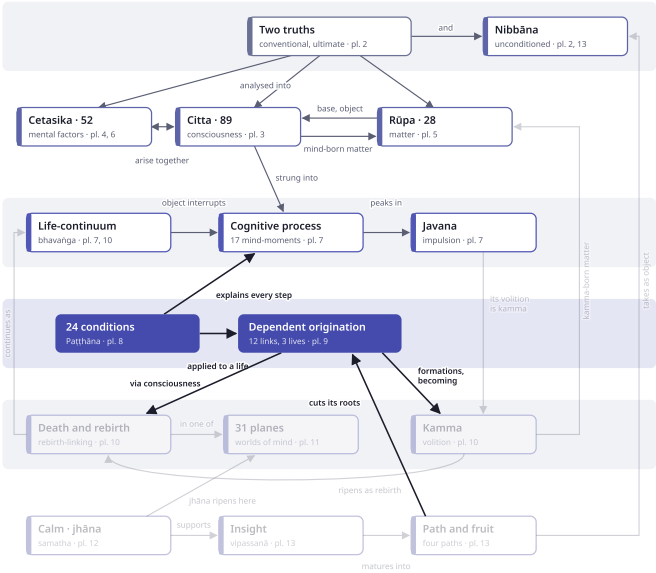
How each dhamma helps another, sorted by direction.

9 The wheel across three lives

Dependent origination and its whole vocabulary in one drawing.

✦ In the stories

Episodes from the Buddha's life, the Jātakas and the disciples, read with these plates.



Filled: this level. Outlined: earlier levels. Faded: what comes later. Bold arrows touch this level.

CHECK YOURSELF AT THREE DEPTHS

Learn *suta*

recall the lists and terms

1. Which two links are the roots of the wheel?
2. Name the four conditions that, the Saṅgaha says, include all 24.

Reflect *cintā*

connect and explain

1. Contact and feeling arise together, yet contact is listed first. What kind of order is the list showing?
2. Why must the Paṭṭhāna allow concepts, not only dhammas, to be objects?

Observe *bhāvanā*

find it in experience

1. Trace one craving back: what feeling came just before it, and what contact before that?

Common confusions

≠ Conditions are not billiard balls in a chain. Many of them hold between things that arise at the same time.

≠ The three-life reading is the Saṅgaha's standard, but the Vibhaṅga also applies the twelve links within a single moment of mind.

IV Relations Builds on 7 Leads to 9

citta contact kamma matter roots jhāna

The web of 24 conditions

The Paṭṭhāna asks one question of every pair of dhammas: how does this one help that one arise or persist? Its 24 answers fall into six families according to direction, mind or matter on each side. The Saṅgaha adds that all 24 fold into four, a good place to start: **object** (what is known), **decisive support** (what strongly backed it), **kamma** (what volition produced it) and **presence** (what had to exist at the same time).

Mind → mind 6

4 proximity · 5 contiguity · 12 repetition · 19 association · 22 absence · 23 disappearance

Each citta, as it ceases, gives way to the next: the stream has no gaps. Javanas strengthen their successors.

Mind → mind & matter 5

1 root · 13 kamma · 14 result · 17 jhāna · 18 path

Roots, jhāna and path factors steady the citta, its factors and the matter it produces. Volition is kamma.

Mind → matter 1

11 postnascence

Later cittas sustain the body that arose before them. This is postnascence.

Matter → mind 1

10 prenascence

The eye, already arisen, supports the eye-consciousness that follows; so does a visible object already present.

Anything → mind 2

2 object · 9 decisive support

Concepts, mind or matter can all be objects. A strong past experience, a teacher, a habit can decisively support what arises now.

Mind & matter → both 9

3 predominance · 6 conascence · 7 mutuality · 8 support · 15 nutriment · 16 faculty · 20 dissociation · 21 presence · 24 non-disappearance

Things that arise together hold each other up, like the three legs of a tripod.

THE 24 IN THEIR CANONICAL ORDER, COLOURED BY FAMILY

1 *hetu* root	2 *ārammaṇa* object	3 *adhipati* predominance	4 *anantara* proximity	5 *samanantara* contiguity	6 *sahajāta* conascence
7 *aññamañña* mutuality	8 *nissaya* support	9 *upanissaya* decisive support	10 *purejāta* prenascence	11 *pacchājāta* postnascence	12 *āsevana* repetition
13 *kamma* kamma	14 *vipāka* result	15 *āhāra* nutriment	16 *indriya* faculty	17 *jhāna* jhāna	18 *magga* path
19 *sampayutta* association	20 *vippayutta* dissociation	21 *atthi* presence	22 *natthi* absence	23 *vigata* disappearance	24 *avigata* non-disappearance

Worked example: seeing a mango and wanting it → 14

The eye-base, already present, supports eye-consciousness	10 prenascence · 8 support · 21 presence
The mango's colour is the object of eye-consciousness	2 object · 10 prenascence
Five-door adverting gives way to eye-consciousness	4 proximity · 5 contiguity · 22 absence · 23 disappearance
Greed, a root, steadies the javana and its factors	1 root · 6 conascence
Each javana strengthens the next	12 repetition
Contact, feeling and the rest arise together and support each other	6 conascence · 7 mutuality · 19 association
Volition in the javanas can ripen in a later life	13 kamma

Sources: Bodhi, *CMA* VIII; Agganyani, overview of the 24 paccayas

IV Relations Builds on 8 Leads to 10 · 13 · 14

citta · feeling · contact · kamma · roots

The wheel across three lives

The Abhidhamma reads the twelve links of dependent origination across three lives and hangs a whole vocabulary on them: three periods, twelve factors, twenty modes, three connections, four groups, three rounds and two roots. The wheel shows all seven at once.



round of defilements · round of kamma · round of results · root: ignorance, craving · connection

Past causes
1. ignorance
2. formations
3. craving
4. clinging
5. becoming (kamma)

Present effects
1. consciousness
2. mind and matter
3. six sense bases
4. contact
5. feeling

Present causes
1. craving
2. clinging
3. becoming (kamma)
4. ignorance
5. formations

Future effects
1. consciousness
2. mind and matter
3. six sense bases
4. contact
5. feeling

Links 8–10, craving, clinging and becoming, arise in the javanas of Plate 7 → 7. Links 3–7 are the results that Plate 10 follows across the hinge between lives → 10.

IV Relations Retells and reads plates 8–9 ● the Buddha's life ● Jātaka ● disciples

Relations in the stories

The tradition has always taught through lives. Each story is retold briefly from its source. The second part reads it with the plates of this level; those readings are study aids, not claims made by the texts themselves.

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE MN 36; Ud 1.1–1.3

The night of awakening

Under the Bodhi tree, in the first watch of the night he recalled his past lives; in the second he saw beings pass away and reappear according to their kamma; in the third he realised the destruction of the taints. In the days that followed he reviewed dependent origination forward and in reverse.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The three watches map onto the atlas: past lives and the planes (Plates 10–11), kamma and its fruit (Plate 10), and the wheel with its ending (Plates 9 and 13). → 9 → 10 → 13

REFLECT *Why must dependent origination be seen in reverse as well as forward?*

DISCIPLES Vinaya, Mahāvagga I.23

Assaji's four lines

The wanderer Upatissa saw the monk Assaji on alms round and asked for his teacher's doctrine. Assaji gave it in one verse: "Of things that arise from a cause, the Tathāgata has told the cause, and also their cessation." Upatissa, later Sāriputta, gained the eye of Dhamma on hearing it.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The shortest summary of Plates 8 and 9: whatever is conditioned has conditions, and they can cease. Sāriputta went on to become the Abhidhamma's first teacher (Plate 1). → 8 → 9 → 1

REFLECT *Why might a statement about conditions be enough to open the eye of Dhamma?*

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE DN 15

"Do not say so, Ānanda"

Ānanda remarked that dependent origination, though called deep, seemed clear to him. The Buddha replied: "Do not say so, Ānanda. This dependent origination is deep and appears deep. Through not understanding it, this generation has become like a tangled skein."

READ WITH THE ATLAS Plates 8 and 9 make the structure visible, but reading a diagram is learning (suta). Seeing a link happen is development (bhāvanā). → 9

REFLECT *What would it take to move from knowing the twelve links to seeing one of them happen?*

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE Atthasālinī, introduction

Rays from the Jewel House

In the fourth week after the awakening, the commentary says, the Buddha sat in a jewelled chamber and contemplated the Abhidhamma. Through the first six books no rays appeared; when he reached the Paṭṭhāna, rays of six colours streamed from his body.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The tradition marks the Paṭṭhāna, the book behind Plate 8, as the vastest of all. Its colours inspired the modern Buddhist flag. → 8 → 1

REFLECT *Why might the relations between things be harder to see than the things themselves?*

LEVEL V OF VII · PLATES 10–11

Lives and worlds

What carries on from one life to the next, and where?

I · Foundations | II · Elements | III · Process | IV · Relations | **V · Lives and worlds** | VI · Practice | VII · Synthesis

YOU ARRIVE WITH

Level III: javana and the life-continuum. Level IV: dependent origination.

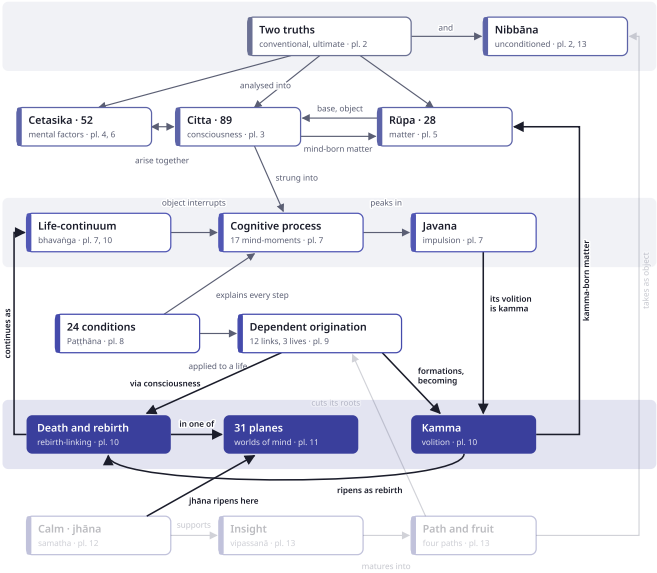
YOU LEAVE ABLE TO

- Sort kamma by function, order, time and place.
- Describe the last process of a life and how rebirth-linking takes its object.
- Match each jhāna to its planes and read their lifespans.

10 Kamma, death and rebirth
Four ways to sort kamma, and the hinge between two lives.

11 Thirty-one planes
The worlds of each level of mind, on a scale of deep time.

✦ In the stories
Episodes from the Buddha's life, the Jātakas and the disciples, read with these plates.



Filled: this level. Outlined: earlier levels. Faded: what comes later. Bold arrows touch this level.

CHECK YOURSELF AT THREE DEPTHS

Learn *suta*

recall the lists and terms

1. What three kinds of object can appear at death?
2. Which plane holds beings with matter but no mind?

Reflect *cintā*

connect and explain

1. Rebirth-linking takes the same object as the last javanas. How does that tie Plate 10 back to Plate 7?
2. Why might habitual kamma matter more, in practice, than any single act?

Observe *bhāvanā*

find it in experience

1. Notice which thoughts return most often as you fall asleep. They are the raw material of habitual kamma.

Common confusions

≠ Kamma is the volition, not its result. Results are vipāka.

≠ Nothing transmigrates. Rebirth-linking is conditioned by the past life, but nothing passes across.

≠ The planes are not only places. Each corresponds to a kind of mind: jhāna kamma ripens in the Brahmā worlds.

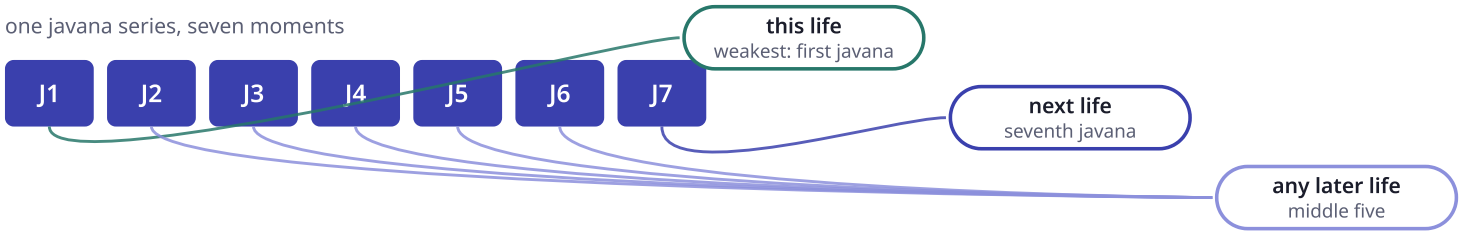
V Lives and worlds Builds on 7 · 9 Leads to 11 kamma bhavaṅga jhāna time

Kamma, death and rebirth

Kamma is volition (*cetanā*). The Saṅgaha sorts it four ways, each answering a different question. Then it follows the last moments of a life into the first moment of the next.

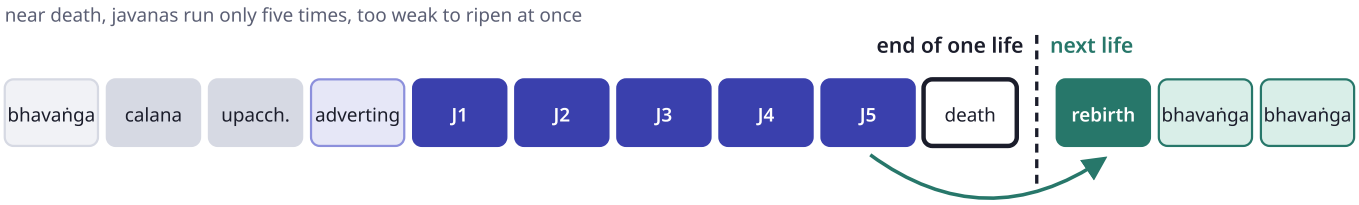
BY FUNCTION: WHAT DOES IT DO?	*janaka* productive: produces rebirth and results during life	*upatthambhaka* supportive: strengthens another kamma's results	*upapīḷaka* obstructive: weakens or delays them	*upaghātaka* destructive: cuts another kamma off and takes its place
BY ORDER: WHICH RIPENS FIRST AT DEATH?	*garuka* weighty: jhāna, or a heinous crime; nothing overrides it	*āsanna* death-proximate: done or recalled just before death	*āciṇṇa* habitual: what one does again and again	*kaṭattā* reserve: anything done once, if nothing else is there
BY TIME: WHEN DOES IT RIPEN?	*diṭṭhadhammavedanīya* in this very life	*upapajjavedanīya* in the next life	*aparāpariyavedanīya* in any later life	*ahosi* defunct: its chance passed
BY PLACE: WHERE DOES IT RIPEN?	*akusala* unwholesome kamma	*kāmāvacara kusala* sense-sphere wholesome	*rūpāvacara kusala* fine-material wholesome: jhāna	*arūpāvacara kusala* immaterial wholesome

WHEN A JAVANA'S KAMMA CAN RIPEN



If the right conditions never come in time, the kamma becomes defunct (*ahosi*). These are the seven javanas of Plate 7 → 7.

THE HINGE BETWEEN TWO LIVES



rebirth-linking takes the same object as the last javanas: a kamma, a kamma sign or a destiny sign

Three signs at death

The last process takes one of three objects: a **kamma** remembered, a **kamma sign** (a sight or sound linked with it, such as flowers offered at a shrine), or a **destiny sign** (an image of the coming birth).

Four causes of death

End of the lifespan, end of the productive kamma, both together, or a destructive kamma cutting in. A lamp goes out the same four ways: the wick is used up, the oil is used up, both run out, or a gust of wind blows it out.

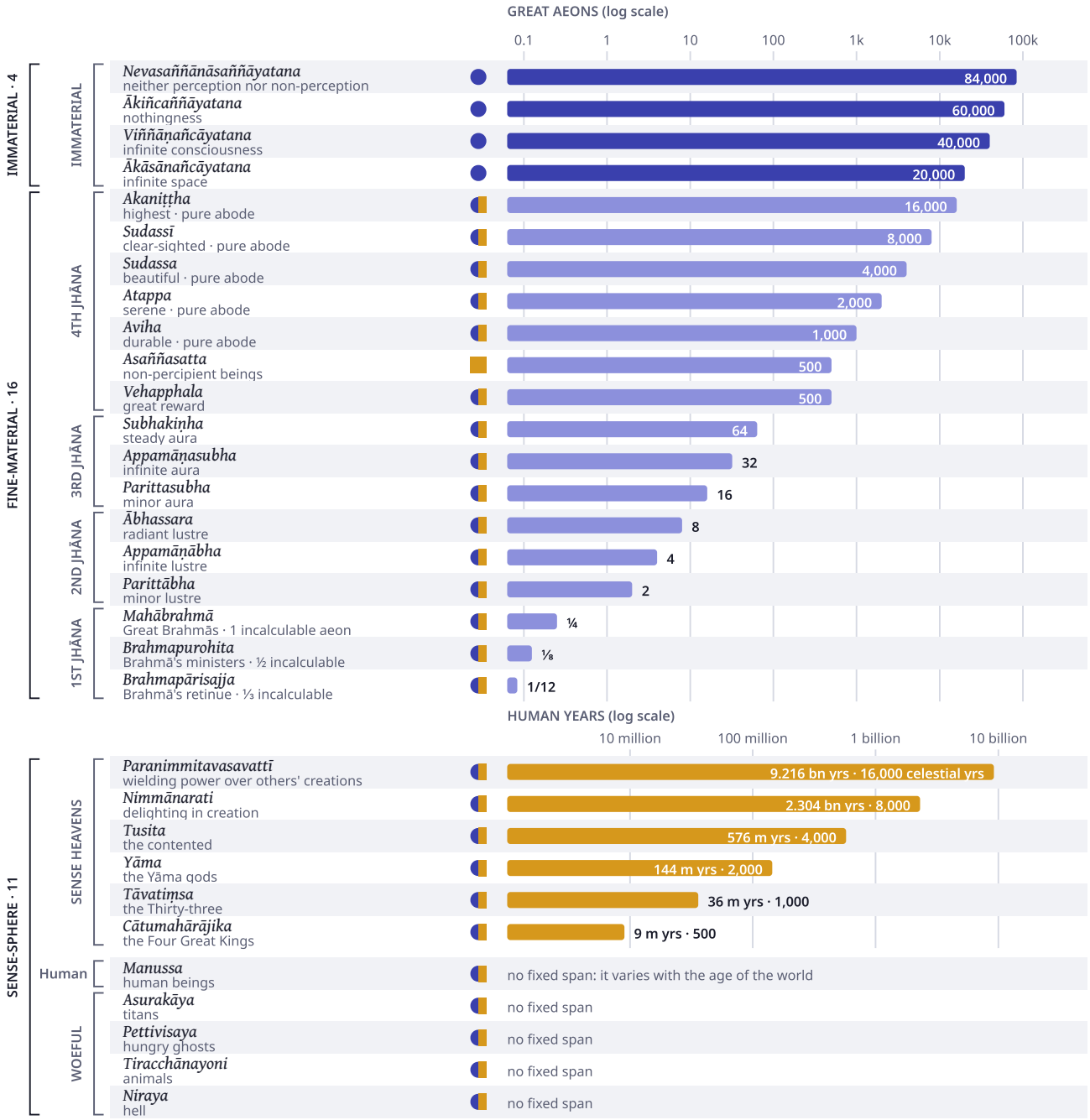
Nothing travels across

Rebirth-linking is conditioned by the past life, but nothing passes over. The Visuddhimagga's images: an echo, the light of a lamp, the impression of a seal, a reflection in a mirror.

V Lives and worlds Builds on 3 · 10 Leads to 12 citta matter jhāna time

Thirty-one planes, on a scale of deep time

The planes match the levels of mind: each jhāna has its own heavens. Plotted on a logarithmic scale, the lifespans rise in steady doublings. The chart also shows which planes hold mind only or matter only.



mind only (immaterial planes) matter only (non-percipient beings) mind and matter

Brahmā lifespans are in great aeons (*mahākappa*). The first three are given in the texts as fractions of an incalculable aeon, a quarter of a great aeon, and are converted here. Deva lifespans are in human years: 50 human years make one day of the Four Great Kings, and each higher heaven doubles both the day and the lifespan. Jhāna kamma ripens in the Brahmā planes → 12.

V Lives and worlds Retells and reads plates 10–11 ● the Buddha's life ● Jātaka ● disciples

Lives and worlds in the stories

The tradition has always taught through lives. Each story is retold briefly from its source. The second part reads it with the plates of this level; those readings are study aids, not claims made by the texts themselves.

DISCIPLES Dhammapada commentary, v. 2

Maṭṭhakuṇḍalī's last thought

A miserly brahmin's son lay dying, left on the veranda so visitors would not see inside the house. The Buddha passed and let himself be seen. The boy's mind filled with faith, he died with that thought, and he was reborn in the Tāvatiṃsa heaven.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Death-proximate kamma on Plate 10: the last javanas were full of faith, and the rebirth-linking that followed took up their object. → 10 → 11

REFLECT *If one last thought can decide a rebirth, why do teachers stress habitual kamma?*

DISCIPLES Dhammapada commentary, v. 151

Queen Mallikā's seven days

Queen Mallikā was generous and devout, but as she died her mind went to one wrong deed she had hidden from the king. She was reborn in a woeful state for seven days, and then in the Tusita heaven.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The other face of death-proximate kamma: one unwholesome last thought outweighed a good life, but only for a while. Her stored good kamma then took its turn (Plate 10). → 10 → 11

REFLECT *Which shapes rebirth more: a whole life, or its last moments?*

DISCIPLES MN 86

Aṅgulimāla and the stones

The bandit Aṅgulimāla had killed many. Meeting the Buddha, he went forth and became an arahant. On alms round people threw stones and sticks at him. The Buddha said: "Bear it, brahmin. You are experiencing here and now the result of deeds for which you might have suffered in hell for many years."

READ WITH THE ATLAS Kamma by time (Plate 10): what could ripen in this life did. With arahantship there is no next life, so kamma waiting for later lives could never ripen. → 10

REFLECT *What does Aṅgulimāla's story say about whether kamma is fate?*

DISCIPLES Vinaya, Cūḷavagga VII; Dhammapada commentary, v. 17

Devadatta's weighty kamma

The Buddha's cousin Devadatta drew the Buddha's blood with a rock hurled from Vulture Peak, and split the Saṅgha. The commentary says that as he came at last to ask forgiveness, the earth swallowed him and he was reborn in the Avīci hell.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Wounding a Buddha and splitting the Saṅgha are two of the five heinous deeds: weighty kamma, which ripens before any other kind (Plate 10). → 10 → 11

REFLECT *Why should weighty kamma override even death-proximate kamma?*

DISCIPLES Dhammapada commentary, vv. 137–140

Why Moggallāna was beaten

Late in life the great disciple Mahā Moggallāna was beaten to death by hired bandits. The commentary traces this to a deed many lives before, when he turned on his own blind parents; versions differ on whether he went through with it.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Kamma that can ripen "in any later life" (Plate 10) waits for its chance, even for an arahant. What arahantship ends is new kamma and any further rebirth. → 10

REFLECT *If even an arahant meets old kamma, what exactly does arahantship end?*

JĀTAKA Ja 541

King Nimi's chariot

Sakka sent his charioteer Mātali to bring the righteous King Nimi to the Tāvatiṃsa heaven. On the way Mātali showed him the hells, naming the deeds that led there, and then the heavenly mansions, naming the deeds that earned them.

READ WITH THE ATLAS A guided tour of Plate 11. Each world is paired with a kind of deed, the same pairing as kamma "by place" on Plate 10. → 11 → 10

REFLECT *Why does the story always show the deed alongside the world?*

VI

LEVEL VI OF VII · PLATES 12–13

Practice

What do I do with all this?

I · Foundations | II · Elements | III · Process | IV · Relations | V · Lives and worlds | **VI · Practice** | VII · Synthesis

YOU ARRIVE WITH

Levels II to IV. Insight takes the elements, the process and the conditions as its objects.

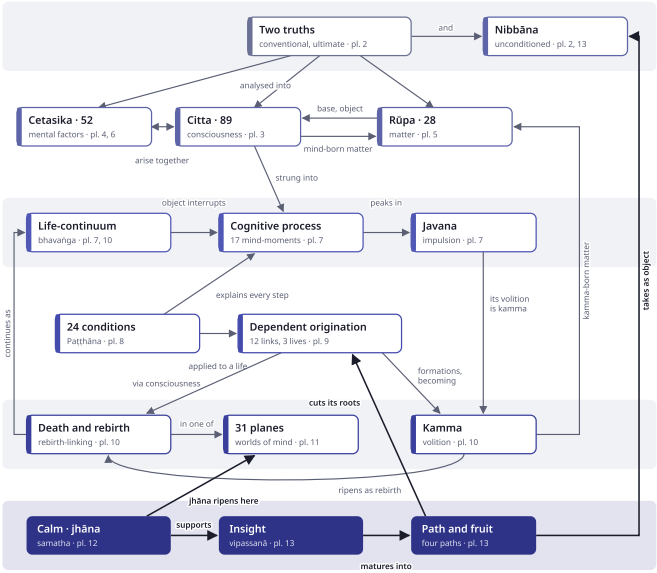
YOU LEAVE ABLE TO

- Choose a meditation subject for a temperament and say how deep it can go.
- Name the three signs and three stages of concentration.
- Order the seven purifications and the ten insight knowledges, and say which fetters each path ends.

12 Forty meditation subjects
Subjects matched to temperaments, and how deep each can go.

13 The tree of purification
The path of insight as soil, roots, trunk and crown.

✦ In the stories
Episodes from the Buddha's life, the Jātakas and the disciples, read with these plates.



Filled: this level. Outlined: earlier levels. Faded: what comes later. Bold arrows touch this level.

CHECK YOURSELF AT THREE DEPTHS

Learn *suta*

recall the lists and terms

1. Which subjects can reach all five jhānas?
2. Which three fetters end at stream-entry?

Reflect *cintā*

connect and explain

1. Purifications 3 and 4 are "defining mind and matter" and "discerning their conditions". Which levels of this atlas do they match?
2. Why does the tree put virtue and concentration at the roots rather than in the trunk?

Observe *bhāvanā*

find it in experience

1. Choose one subject suited to your temperament and practise it daily for a week. Note which sign, if any, appears.

Common confusions

≠ Calm and insight are not rivals. The tree puts concentration at the roots of insight.

≠ The insight knowledges are not ideas about impermanence. They are stages of directly seeing mind and matter arise and pass.

VI Practice Builds on 3 · 11 Leads to 13 feeling jhāna

Forty meditation subjects

Each subject is fitted to a temperament and reaches a known depth. The colour bar on each card shows the temperament it suits. The five boxes show how many jhānas it can reach.

lustful · 11 hateful · 8 deluded · 1 speculative · 1 faithful · 6 intelligent · 4 all temperaments · 10
jhāna reached, 1st to 5th

Kasiṇas 10
- earth ■■■■■
- water ■■■■■
- fire ■■■■■
- air ■■■■■
- blue ■■■■■
- yellow ■■■■■
- red ■■■■■
- white ■■■■■
- light ■■■■■
- limited space ■■■■■

Foulness 10 corpses
- bloated ■□□□□
- livid ■□□□□
- festering ■□□□□
- cut up ■□□□□
- gnawed ■□□□□
- scattered ■□□□□
- hacked and scattered ■□□□□
- bleeding ■□□□□
- worm-infested ■□□□□
- skeleton ■□□□□

Recollections 10
- the Buddha ACCESS
- the Dhamma ACCESS
- the Saṅgha ACCESS
- virtue ACCESS
- generosity ACCESS
- deities ACCESS
- peace ACCESS
- death ACCESS
- the body ■□□□□
- breathing ■■■■■

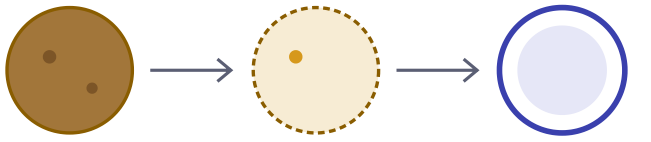
Illimitables 4
- loving-kindness ■■■■□
- compassion ■■■■□
- appreciative joy ■■■■□
- equanimity □□□□■

Perception 1
- repulsiveness of food ACCESS

Analysis 1
- the four elements ACCESS

Immaterial 4
- infinite space IMMATERIAL
- infinite consciousness IMMATERIAL
- nothingness IMMATERIAL
- neither perception nor non-perception IMMATERIAL

THREE SIGNS, THREE STAGES (EARTH KASIṆA)



preliminary sign *parikamma-nimitta* → learning sign *uggaha-nimitta* → counterpart sign *paṭibhāga-nimitta*

preliminary development → access, when the counterpart sign appears → absorption (jhāna), when the factors grow strong.

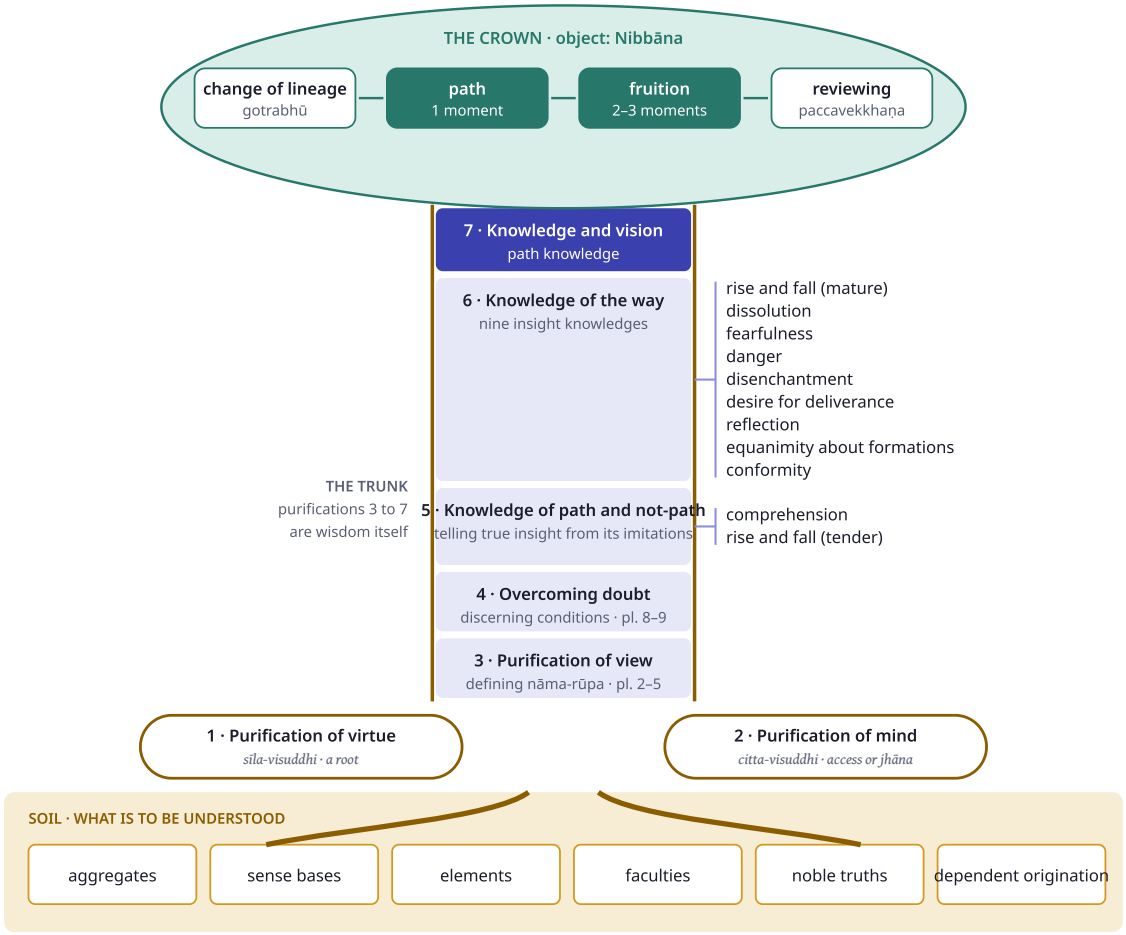
Reading the depths

- **Access only** (10 subjects): the object is too varied or too deep in thought to settle into absorption.
- **First jhāna only** (11): foulness and the parts of the body need applied thought to hold the object.
- **Four jhānas** (3): loving-kindness, compassion and appreciative joy come with pleasant feeling, so they stop before the fifth.
- **Fifth only** (1): equanimity as a divine abiding needs neutral feeling.
- **All five** (11): the kasiṇas and the breath. The immaterial four build on the fifth. → 11

VI Practice Builds on 9 · 12 Leads to 14 roots jhāna Nibbāna wisdom

The tree of purification

The Visuddhimagga pictures the path of insight as a tree. The things to be understood are the soil. Virtue and a concentrated mind are the roots. The five purifications of wisdom are the trunk, and the insight knowledges grow up it.



TEN FETTERS AND THE FOUR PATHS

Fetter	Stream-entry	Once-return	Non-return	Arahantship
personality view	■			
doubt	■			
clinging to rites and rules	■			
sensual desire		▮	■	
ill will		▮	■	
lust for fine-material being				■
lust for immaterial being				■
conceit				■
restlessness				■
ignorance				■

■ abandoned ▮ weakened

Three doors to liberation

Insight that ends in path enters by one of three doors, set by the characteristic it dwelt on most.

- Impermanence → the **signless** (*animitta*)
- Suffering → the **desireless** (*appaṇihita*)
- Non-self → the **void** (*suññata*)

At the crown, a single moment of path knowledge is followed by two or three moments of fruition, both taking Nibbāna as their object.

VI Practice Retells and reads plates 12–13 ● the Buddha's life ● Jātaka ● disciples

Practice in the stories

The tradition has always taught through lives. Each story is retold briefly from its source. The second part reads it with the plates of this level; those readings are study aids, not claims made by the texts themselves.

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE MN 36

The rose-apple tree

As a boy, the Bodhisatta sat in the shade of a rose-apple tree while his father worked at a ploughing ceremony, and entered the first jhāna. Years later, worn out by austerities, he remembered it and asked: "Could that be the path to awakening?"

READ WITH THE ATLAS On Plate 13's tree, concentration is a root. The commentaries say his subject was the breath, one of the eleven that can reach all five jhānas on Plate 12. → 12 → 13

REFLECT *Why was a pleasant, blameless state the clue, after years of pain?*

DISCIPLES Dhammapada commentary, v. 25

Cūḷapanthaka's white cloth

Cūḷapanthaka could not learn a single verse in four months, and his brother told him to leave. The Buddha gave him a clean white cloth to rub while repeating "removing dirt". As the cloth grew soiled he saw impermanence, and he became an arahant.

READ WITH THE ATLAS A subject fitted to the person (Plate 12): a simple object you can see and touch, which ripened into insight (Plate 13). → 12 → 13

REFLECT *Why might a slow learner of words be a quick learner of seeing?*

DISCIPLES Dhammapada commentary, v. 285; Ja 25

The goldsmith and the lotus

A young monk, a goldsmith for five hundred lives, made no progress with meditation on the foulness of the body. The Buddha gave him a lotus instead. Its beauty steadied his mind; then the flower withered, and he saw impermanence.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Plate 12's temperaments in action: the usual remedy for lust did not fit this mind, and a beautiful object did. → 12

REFLECT *Which of Plate 12's six temperaments sounds most like your own?*

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE MN 26

Āḷāra and Uddaka

Before his awakening, the Bodhisatta reached the base of nothingness under Āḷāra Kālāma, and neither perception nor non-perception under Uddaka Rāmaputta. He left both, seeing they did not lead to Nibbāna. After awakening he thought first of teaching them, but both had died.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The highest calm leads to the highest immaterial planes of Plate 11, with lifespans of 60,000 and 84,000 aeons, but not out of the round. That is why Plate 13's tree needs a trunk of insight. → 11 → 12 → 13

REFLECT *What does insight supply that even the highest jhāna lacks?*

DISCIPLES Therīgāthā 112–116

Paṭācārā and the water

Having lost her whole family, Paṭācārā became a nun. Washing her feet, she watched the water trickle down, some a little way, some further, like the stages of a life. That night, as she drew down the wick of her lamp, her mind was freed.

READ WITH THE ATLAS The knowledge of rise and fall on Plate 13, seen first in water and then in her own mind. The lamp going out echoes Plate 10's image of death. → 13 → 10

REFLECT *Why is the going-out of a flame so often the image of Nibbāna?*

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE SN 56.11

Koṇḍañña's eye of Dhamma

At the first sermon in the Deer Park, as the Buddha finished, Koṇḍañña understood: "Whatever is subject to arising is all subject to cessation." The Buddha exclaimed, "Koṇḍañña has understood!"

READ WITH THE ATLAS Stream-entry (Plate 13): the first three fetters fall away, and path knowledge takes Nibbāna as its object for the first time. → 13

REFLECT *Why is the insight put as a general rule rather than a particular experience?*

VII

LEVEL VII OF VII · PLATES 14–15

Synthesis

How does it all fit together, and how do others see it?

I · Foundations | II · Elements | III · Process | IV · Relations | V · Lives and worlds | VI · Practice | **VII · Synthesis**

YOU ARRIVE WITH

Everything before. This level is for review and perspective.

YOU LEAVE ABLE TO

- Describe one moment of experience through every lens in the atlas.
- Compare the Theravāda list with the Sarvāstivāda and Yogācāra lists.
- Follow any key idea through every plate where it appears.

14 One moment, every lens

One moment of seeing and wanting, read through ten frameworks.

15 Other maps of the same ground

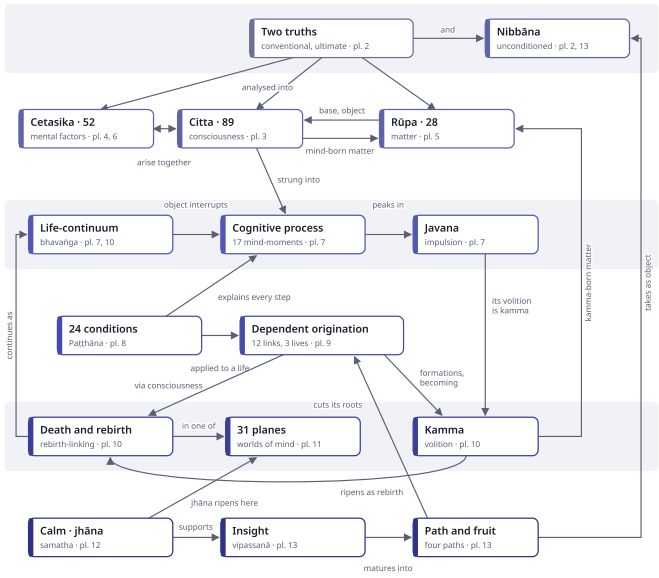
How two other schools counted the elements.

✦ In the stories

Episodes from the Buddha's life, the Jātakas and the disciples, read with these plates.

↯ Threads and glossary

Every key idea traced across the plates, and the terms that name them.



Synthesis uses the whole map.

CHECK YOURSELF AT THREE DEPTHS

Learn *suta*

recall the lists and terms

1. How many elements does each of the three schools count?
2. Which thread runs through the most plates?

Reflect *cintā*

connect and explain

1. If the past and future were as real as the present, which plates would have to change?
2. The Paṭṭhāna already relates everything to everything. What does a concept map add, and what does it leave out?

Observe *bhāvanā*

find it in experience

1. Fill in the worksheet on Plate 14 for one moment of your own day.

Common confusions

≠ Different counts do not always mean different claims. Much of the difference lies in how things are grouped.

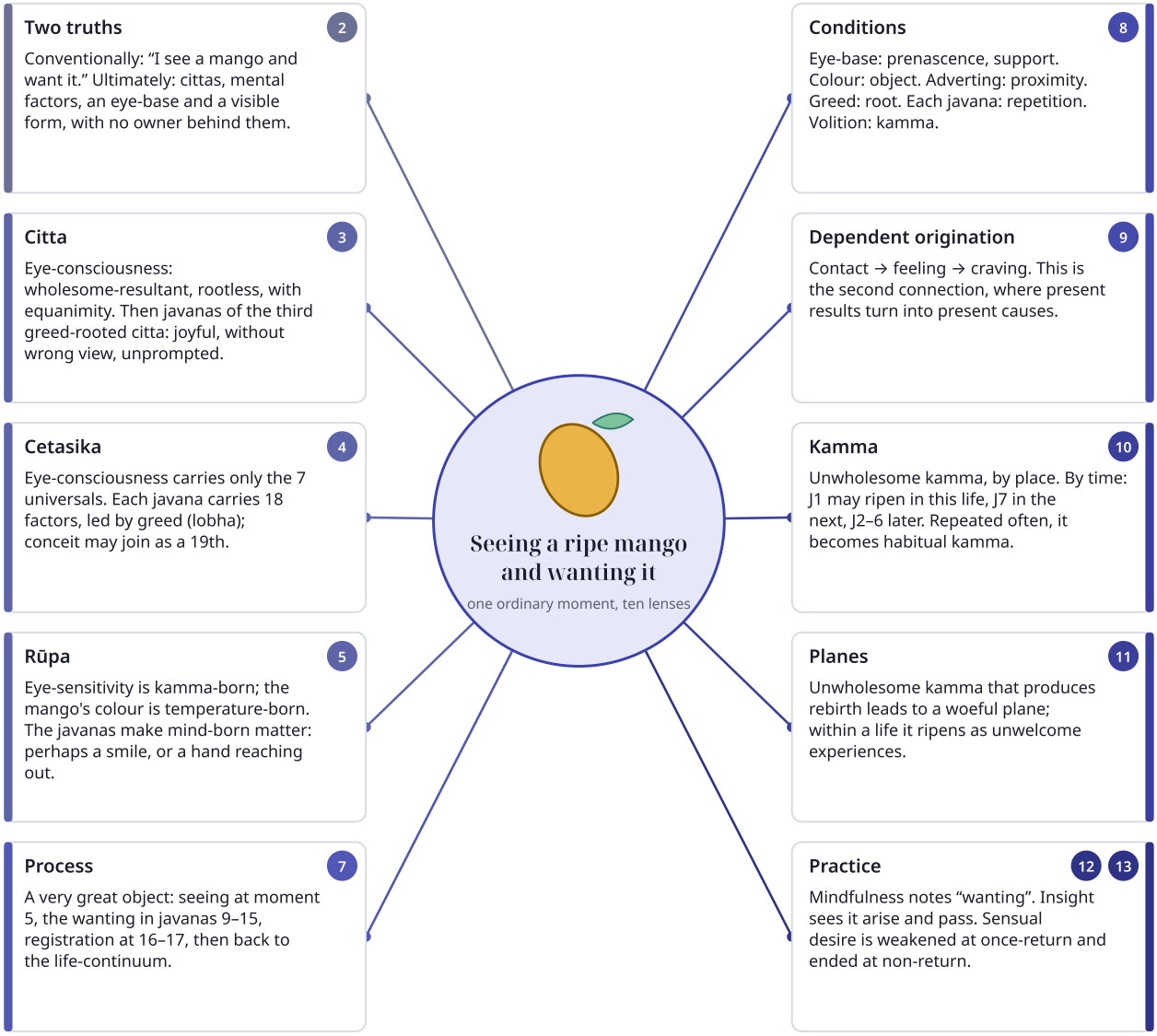
≠ Synthesis is not a new doctrine. These pages only make visible the links the texts already draw.

VII Synthesis Builds on 2–13 Leads to 15

citta · feeling · contact · kamma · matter · bhavaṅga · roots · wisdom

One moment, every lens

Every plate so far describes the same experience from a different angle. Here one ordinary moment, seeing a ripe mango and wanting it, is read through ten of them at once. Each lens points back to the plate that teaches it.



Two truths 2
Conventionally: "I see a mango and want it." Ultimately: cittas, mental factors, an eye-base and a visible form, with no owner behind them.

Citta 3
Eye-consciousness: wholesome-resultant, rootless, with equanimity. Then javanas of the third greed-rooted citta: joyful, without wrong view, unprompted.

Cetasika 4
Eye-consciousness carries only the 7 universals. Each javana carries 18 factors, led by greed (lobha); conceit may join as a 19th.

Rūpa 5
Eye-sensitivity is kamma-born; the mango's colour is temperature-born. The javanas make mind-born matter: perhaps a smile, or a hand reaching out.

Process 7
A very great object: seeing at moment 5, the wanting in javanas 9–15, registration at 16–17, then back to the life-continuum.

Conditions 8
Eye-base: prenascence, support. Colour: object. Adverting: proximity. Greed: root. Each javana: repetition. Volition: kamma.

Dependent origination 9
Contact → feeling → craving. This is the second connection, where present results turn into present causes.

Kamma 10
Unwholesome kamma, by place. By time: J1 may ripen in this life, J7 in the next, J2–6 later. Repeated often, it becomes habitual kamma.

Planes 11
Unwholesome kamma that produces rebirth leads to a woeful plane; within a life it ripens as unwelcome experiences.

Practice 12 13
Mindfulness notes "wanting". Insight sees it arise and pass. Sensual desire is weakened at once-return and ended at non-return.

Your turn

Pick one moment from today, such as hearing your name or tasting something sweet, and answer each lens in a line.

Two truths · In everyday words, and in dhammas?

Citta · Which kind, and with what feeling?

Cetasika · Which factor led: greed, aversion, mindfulness?

Rūpa · Which base, and which object?

Process · Which door, and how strong an object?

Conditions · What was the object, the root, the strong support?

Dependent origination · Did feeling turn into craving?

Kamma · What was the volition? Is it a habit?

Planes · What kind of world does this mind belong to?

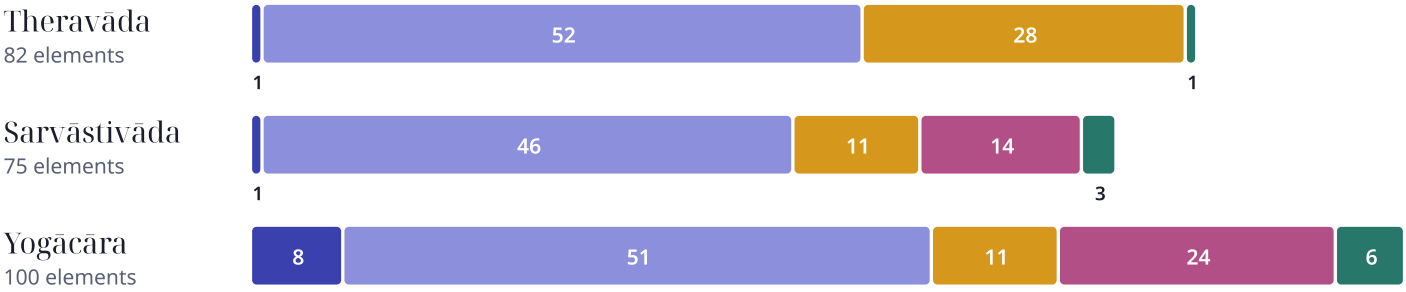
Practice · What would mindfulness have noticed?

VII Synthesis Builds on 14 Threads and glossary

citta matter bhavaṅga Nibbāna time

Other maps of the same ground

Three Buddhist schools analysed experience into ultimate elements and reached different lists. Comparing them shows which choices were open. Counted the same way, with citta as one element, the Theravāda list has 82 items.



Time

The Sarvāstivāda held that dhammas exist in the past, present and future; hence its name, “the doctrine that all exists”. The Theravāda Kathāvatthu argues against this. For the Theravāda only the present moment is real.

A fifth category

Northern lists add “formations dissociated from mind”: possession, life force, the arising and decay of things, words. The Theravāda has no such category. It treats most of these as concepts, or as aspects of matter and mind.

The base of mind

Yogācāra counts eight consciousnesses, including a storehouse consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) that carries seeds of past action. The Theravāda's life-continuum (*bhavaṅga*) is often compared with it, though it is momentary and stores nothing.

Research notes

This atlas was built from two rounds of research. The first surveyed the canonical books, the commentaries and manuals, and modern studies, looking for how each explains the material. The second checked the specific claims used here: the groupings of the 24 conditions, the plane lifespans, the wording and source of each simile, and the counts of the northern schools. Where the texts give a range, or where a figure was confirmed only by secondary sources, the plate says so.

Principal sources: Bhikkhu Bodhi (ed.), *A Comprehensive Manual of Abhidhamma* (BPS, 1993); Nārada, *A Manual of Abhidhamma*; Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli (tr.), *The Path of Purification*; *The Expositor* (Atthasālinī), tr. Pe Maung Tin; *Milindapañha*; Nyanaponika, *Abhidhamma Studies*; Y. Karunadasa, *The Theravāda Abhidhamma*; L. S. Cousins (1992) on vitakka and vicāra; M. Heim on nāmarūpa in Buddhaghosa; Agganyani's Paṭṭhāna overview; Encyclopedia of Buddhism entries on the 75 and 100 dharmas.

VII Synthesis Retells and reads plates 14–15 ● the Buddha's life ● Jātaka ● disciples

Synthesis in the stories

The tradition has always taught through lives. Each story is retold briefly from its source. The second part reads it with the plates of this level; those readings are study aids, not claims made by the texts themselves.

JĀTAKA Buddhavaṃsa II; Jātaka introduction

Sumedha's vow

Ages ago, the ascetic Sumedha lay down in the mud so that the Buddha Dīpaṅkara could walk across him, and resolved to become a Buddha himself. Dīpaṅkara foretold it. Four incalculable aeons and a hundred thousand aeons of perfections followed.

READ WITH THE ATLAS One volition (Plate 4), renewed and fulfilled across lives (Plate 10), in worlds measured in aeons (Plate 11): the whole atlas in a single vow. → 4 → 10 → 11

REFLECT *In Abhidhamma terms, what continues from Sumedha to Siddhattha?*

JĀTAKA Ja 547

Vessantara's gifts

In the last human life before the final one, the Bodhisatta as Prince Vessantara gave away the kingdom's white elephant, his wealth, and in the end his children and his wife. After that life he was reborn in the Tusita heaven.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Sense-sphere wholesome kamma at its fullest (Plate 10). The tradition counts it as the completion of the perfection of giving. → 10 → 11

REFLECT *Can giving be wholesome kamma and also a step toward ending kamma?*

DISCIPLES DN 2

Ajātasattu's lost chance

King Ajātasattu, who had killed his father to take the throne, heard the Buddha's discourse on the fruits of the recluse's life and went for refuge. When he had left, the Buddha said that had he not killed his father, the eye of Dhamma would have arisen in him then and there.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Weighty kamma (Plate 10) can bar the path (Plate 13). A heinous deed closes the door to path attainment in that life. → 10 → 13

REFLECT *Why can one past act close a door that a good present act cannot open?*

THE BUDDHA'S LIFE DN 16

The last night at Kusinārā

The Buddha's last words were: “All conditioned things are subject to decay. Strive on with diligence.” He then rose through the jhānas to the cessation of perception and feeling, came back down to the first jhāna, rose again to the fourth, and on emerging from it attained final Nibbāna.

READ WITH THE ATLAS Every level at once: the jhānas of Plates 3 and 12, the planes he would not return to (11), and a death followed by no rebirth-linking (10). → 3 → 10 → 12 → 13

REFLECT *In terms of Plate 10, how does an arahant's death differ from anyone else's?*

Threads: following one idea through the atlas

Eleven key ideas run through many plates. Each coloured line is one idea; each stop is a plate where it appears. Plate 14 is the interchange where most of them meet. To review, pick a line and read its plates in order. The same colours mark the threads in the strip at the top of every plate.



GLOSSARY · THE PLATE WHERE EACH TERM IS TAUGHT

abhidhamma the "higher teaching": experience analysed into dhammas · 1
avijjā ignorance, a root of the wheel · 9, 13
cetanā volition; kamma itself · 4, 10
dhamma an ultimate, irreducible event · 2
kalāpa smallest group of matter · 5

lakkhaṇa characteristic · 2
nibbāna the unconditioned · 2, 13
paññā wisdom, understanding · 6, 13
phassa contact · 2, 4
saññā perception · 6
taṇhā craving, a root of the wheel · 9
vipāka result of kamma · 3, 10
visuddhi purification · 13

āhāra nutriment; nutritive essence · 5, 8

bhavaṅga life-continuum · 7, 10
cetasika mental factor · 4
jhāna meditative absorption · 12
kamma volitional action · 10

magga path of a noble person · 13
nimitta sign; in meditation, the mental image · 12
paṭicca-samuppāda dependent origination · 9
rūpa matter · 5
saṅkhāra formations · 2, 9
upekkhā equanimity; neutral feeling · 3
viññāṇa consciousness, as an aggregate · 2
vitakka applied thought · 6, 12

ārammaṇa the object of a citta · 7, 8

bhūmi plane of existence · 11
citta consciousness: one moment of knowing · 3
javana impulsion, the active phase of a process · 7
kasiṇa a device for concentration, such as a disc of earth · 12
nāma mind: citta with its factors · 2
paccaya condition · 8
paṭisandhi rebirth-linking · 10
sammuti convention · 2
sati mindfulness · 2, 4
vedanā feeling: pleasant, painful or neutral · 3
vīthi cognitive process · 7
vicāra sustained thought · 6